The Midnight Whistle

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Travel Notice · 1/2

CH31101-01

This is no ordinary train.

From Istanbul to Vienna, each land it passes through still carries the echoes of gunshots and explosions.

Before the war, it was a symbol of luxury.
Now it is an ark, a way to outrun death, and everyone is scrambling for a ticket.

They have no idea that when night falls and the train stops, death comes aboard too.

On one such night, a group of passengers awoke to the sound of crying. They followed it.
Then the crying turned to bawling, and the bawling to wailing, until they reached it—

A door that wasn't there before. And there, in a carriage that never was, in that place that shouldn't even have existed,
blood-red eyes blinked in the darkness.

Before they could utter a scream, they were pulled into the darkness,
doomed to join the wailing of the dead and dying in their accursed chorus.

As the night fell and the last slivers of light gave in to the darkness, their cries faded …

And the blood of those sorry passengers trickled, sweet and warm, into the throats of the red-eyed monsters.

Only when that last drop had been swallowed up did the conductress appear. Walking amidst the shredded flesh,
counting off each passenger the way a butler might inspect a mess left behind from his master's feast.

"… 231, 232. The ceremony is complete, and this journey has come to an end."

"We hope you had a pleasant trip, and we look forward to seeing you again aboard …"

"The 'Danube Dawn'!"

Train Station

Hatted Boy: The "Danube Dawn" …

The boy mutters the words one last time, then closes his notebook and hands it back to the woman beside him.

Hatted Boy: Ha! I haven't been able to read a vampire story since the war started. Thank you, kindly ma'am!

???: It's just one of many stories in my collection. I suppose it's interesting enough, then?

Hatted Boy: You suppose?! It's amazing! And the next train coming into the station is called the "Danube Dawn" too, you know!

Hatted Boy: Hah. So it's the same train, isn't it? The vampires' secret base!

???: Ha, the folly of youth. Not yet able to discern fiction from reality.

Hatted Boy: Well, it's not like these stories just spring up out of nowhere. I've heard all kinds of them that really happened. At least, I think so. What do you think, ma'am?

He blinks his shadowed eyes at the woman, then lowers the brim of his hat.

???: What I think is of little matter. I simply write what I see, and I see an intriguing story in you.

???: May I have your name?

Rubuska: Rubuska! My name's Rubuska. Pleasure to meet you, ma'am!

???: Rubuska ... An interesting name. I'll be sure to make a record of it. As I said, I'm a collector of stories, and you may just have something worth adding to my collection.

She opens her notebook, her shining pen tracing a line across the page.

Rubuska: I'd love to, ma'am! But you're about to board the train, aren't you? I'm only here for a visit, so it's pretty much impossible I'll ever see you again.

???: I wouldn't be so sure.

She spins the pen idly between her fingers and looks up.

???: Many a great tale started with the "impossible."

Passenger I: Vampires on a train, eh? Hahahaha, that old tale.

The comment drifts lazily out from another passenger. It seems the tale has a few more listeners than expected.

Rubuska: Old tale? You've heard the story before, sir?

Passenger I: No, no, not precisely, but many like it. Vampires, werewolves, wild beasts, and monsters.

Passenger I: It's always the same story about the powerful consuming the common folk. Heh, storytellers have always been good at making their points one way or another.

Rubuska: Uhh, that doesn't seem like the same thing to me. What do you think, ma'am?

Rubuska turns to look, but the woman who told the story has vanished.

Passenger I: Hahahahaha! You're young. You'll grow out of these tall tales soon enough.

Rubuska: You really don't think vampires are real?

Passenger I: Ah, I'm much too old to believe in that kind of rubbish. I don't see why it's necessary to even put vampires in that one anyway.

The old man exhales a long ring of smoke. He bends down, rubbing the raw seam where his prosthetic meets his severed leg.

Rubuska: Of course it's necessary.

The boy nods gravely, turning toward the direction of the oncoming train.

Rubuska: Think about it—the story's about death, right? And vampires kill, sure, but they also give eternal life.

Rubuska: So, say one of the passengers is killed. The vampire can just bite them on the neck, and just like that, they're alive again! Take out the vampires, and now death is a one-way trip—the end of the line!

Rubuska: It's way more exciting to have some twists and turns. I mean, where's the fun in a story you can predict from the very beginning?

Passenger I: Ah. You're in for a disappointment looking at things like that. The world is filled with predictable endings, usually predictably tragic.

The old man, a half-burned cigarette between his fingers, gestures toward a corner of the station,

where a mass of figures huddle together, clothes worn, cheeks red with frost.

Silent and stubborn, they've fixed their gaze on the frozen tracks ahead of them.

Passenger I: Just look at those poor folk over there. They've been waiting here for days.

Passenger I: How do you think their story will end? Do you think they have tickets in their pockets? Hmph, of course not. But they're hungry and afraid to face the gunfire, so they come here to try their luck.

Passenger I: *sigh* But miracles are few and far between in this world.

The boy pats his empty stomach, chewing on the meaning behind the old man's words.

Rubuska: Try their luck? What sort of luck are you talking about exactly?

Passenger I: I'm sure you're well aware already.

His weathered eyes gaze out over the station, as if awaiting a drama soon to unfold.

Rubuska: Hah, ah, you're confusing me, sir. Weren't we just talking about stories?

The boy bends to brush the dust from his knees. As he does, the crowd begins to move.

At that moment, the station bell tolls, and a voice rings out over the din.

Station Staff: The next train will arrive in twenty minutes. Please line up, taking care to bring all your belongings, and prepare your tickets for inspection.

Civilian I: It's coming—The "Danube Dawn."

Civilian II: This is my chance.

The crowd rises and surges toward the boarding gate.

Rubuska: Well, I better get going now. I mean, my train is here. God bless you, sir! Whichever god that is!

He waves to the old man before slipping into the crowd like a drop falling into the sea.

No one notices his movement; all they care about are tickets, loved ones far away, and the train about to arrive,

along with a troublesome mission.

Semmelweis: November 30th, 1912, the "Danube Dawn" is arriving at ...

Semmelweis: Vampires ... Infection ...

Semmelweis: Manus Vindictae ...

The investigator lingers on the name.

Semmelweis: Didn't expect I'd be dealing with Manus Vindictae for my first field mission after the 5th "Storm."

Semmelweis: According to current intelligence, the vampire working with the Manus is set to board this train.

Semmelweis: I was hoping I'd be able to finish this job with my new teammates. Get this done quickly.

Semmelweis: It looks like this won't be so easy.

She sighs and draws a communicator from her coat pocket.

Semmelweis: Istros Operation Squad 77; rendezvous: train station; time: 18:20 hours ...

Semmelweis: Still no answer. I never realized the "Storm" could affect people's punctuality, too.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: Fine, if the train arrives and they're still not here, then—Hm?

More and more people stream into the station. The platform heaves with bodies, far beyond the capacity of a single train.

Passenger III: Don't push, damn it! Do you even have a ticket?

Passenger IV: For crying out loud, the train isn't even here yet!

Complaints rise, anxiety spreads. The fragile order of the station collapses.

A scream pierces out above the din.

Arrogant Passenger: No, my ticket!

Station Staff: Sir, please give that ticket back to that lady.

Maniacal Civilian: What are you talking about? This is my ticket!

Arrogant Passenger: Your ticket? You just snatched it from my hand! Everyone just saw it!

The man remains unaffected by her scolding.

Station Staff: Sir, there will be other trains. Everyone will have the chance to leave. I need you to calm down, understand?

Station Staff: Our tickets have been specially processed to prevent misuse, so you won't be able to use that ticket.

Maniacal Civilian: Other trains? Hey, everyone! Listen to me! I have firsthand information that this is the last train out of here! It's now or never! No one's leaving here after tonight!

Station Staff: Sir ... SIR!

Shouts and children's cries intertwine with whistles and pops of steam, drowning out all persuasion.

Maniacal Civilian: You don't know what it's like out there. We could all be dead by tomorrow!

Arrogant Passenger: Oh, enough of your blithering excuses! Give me my ticket back now! You can save your heroic speech for—

Arrogant Passenger: AHH!

Before she finishes, he yanks her toward him.

Passengers with tickets scream. The ticketless stand silent, numb eyes locked on him.

Station Staff: Sir! Please, drop the weapon.

Maniacal Civilian: Let me in. I'll shoot her. I'll shoot you. I'll shoot everyone!

He clamps her throat and backs away, dragging her from the yellow lamplight into the shadow behind.

Maniacal Civilian: You really think I'm just going to be a good little sheep and go back home to wait for a bomb to fall on my head?

A hollow laugh escapes him, blood rising in his eyes.

Maniacal Civilian: No, no, no. If I don't get to make it out of here, then no one else will.

A gunshot splits the air. Silence falls over the crowd.

Platform Guard: Hold it, you bastard! Get your hands off that lady!

Guards rush forward, training their rifles on the troublemaker.

Platform Guard: Don't make us end this the hard way.

Maniacal Civilian: Heh ...

Maniacal Civilian: He sneers at the dark muzzles.

Maniacal Civilian: Aren't you soldiers busy enough killing each other? You have to come and start roughing us up too?

His pupils shrink. His finger tightens on the trigger.

Maniacal Civilian: Alright, then try me. Let's see who can pull the trigger first?

Top-Secret Mission

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St. Pavlov Foundation External Field Report: The "Danube Dawn"

Mission Number: XXX-1912-XX-13
Location: The "Danube Dawn"
Security Level: Top Secret

Intelligence Summary:

Key Report 1: Multiple investigation records indicate that during the past three operation cycles (exact dates in encrypted attachment), abnormal arcanum energy traces were consistently detected inside the "Danube Dawn," the international train running between Istanbul and Vienna. These energy patterns closely match the activity signature of a known Beyond entity—the vampire (see encrypted attachment for detailed characteristics).
Key Report 2: Meanwhile, a series of unexplained deaths and disappearances have occurred along the train's route.
Preliminary examinations show that the victims suffered blunt-force trauma and displayed tissue mutations of unidentified form, differing from the pattern of known vampire "Infected." The upper division suspects direct contact with a new strain of vampire. Threat level has been classified as severe.

All evidence suggests the presence of an anomalous vampire aboard the "Danube Dawn"—either active on a periodic cycle or as a vampire "Infected" with atypical traits.
Squad members are to prioritize personal safety during the operation.

Mission Objectives:

Based on prior performance, Level Four Investigator Semmelweis is hereby assigned to the "Danube Dawn" investigation team. Objectives include:
1. Board the "Danube Dawn," confirm the authenticity and number of vampire entities, observe their activity pattern, and assess passenger threat level.
2. Investigate whether vampire activity correlates with newly observed vampire "Infected" incidents along the train's route. Record any newly discovered strains, their traits, and behavioral patterns.
3. Collect direct evidence of collaboration between "Manus Vindictae" and the vampire.

Investigator Semmelweis is to rendezvous with four members of the Istros Operation Squad 77 after the "Danube Dawn" docks at Platform 3, Station G, 6:20 PM local time, November 30, 1912. They will supply all mission-critical resources and equipment.

St. Pavlov Foundation

November 2, 1912

Travel Notice · 2/2

CH31101-01

In the chaos, the shaken "hostage" is pulled back by the platform guards.

Platform Guard: Are you alright, ma'am?

Arrogant Passenger: I'm fine, but my ticket ... He still has my ticket!

She points toward the culprit ahead, who now charges like a mad bull.

Maniacal Civilian: Out of my way!

He finally shakes off the guards and bolts toward the misty tracks.

Maniacal Civilian: Budapest! That's the only safe place.

Maniacal Civilian: Ah!

The world tilts.

The ground gives way beneath him. He slips from the platform.

Arrogant Passenger: Good Lord!

Station Staff: Sir, take my hand. The train's coming.

Cries, screams, and whistles rise in chorus, nearly drowning the train's steam whistle in the distance.

Maniacal Civilian: ...

The man stands dazed in the center of the tracks. His legs are bent at obtuse angles, broken and bleeding.

But he smiles.

A thick black column of smoke cuts into the dusky sky, rising along with a loud whistle.

Civilian I: It's the train. It's the "Danube Dawn"!

Year after year, the shadow of war clings to this land, relentless, unshakable.

But still, the "Danube Dawn" makes its journey, like a dutiful soldier marching alone through rain, sleet, and storm.

She arrives bearing hope for freedom and for life.

Maniacal Civilian: The "Danube Dawn" ... Budapest ...

At last, he remembers what he must do and stumbles toward the engine.

Station Staff: No, sir! No—!

Maniacal Civilian: I made it. Mother, Father, Malina ...

The train exhales smoke as it nears, headlights spilling dim yellow circles into the twilight.

The man limps forward along the tracks.

Maniacal Civilian: Here's my ticket. Let me in. Let me in!

He cries out, waving the thin ticket in the air.

He waves it like a protective charm, like the key to life were in his hand.

Maniacal Civilian: I have a ticket—!

The train thunders as it grinds to a stop—too late. Momentum and weight carried on iron wheels pulverize his flesh,

crushing rage, madness, and fear—everything—into the cold steel.

The bloodstained ticket slips from his fingers, carried up and far away.

The train door opens, and a stewardess with an eyepatch rushes out in a panic.

Train Stewardess: Oh my ...

Train Stewardess: Everyone, please remain calm. We need to inspect the scene.

Civilian I: Please let me in, miss! For the love of all that's good, don't let us die out here.

Civilian II: This is the last train, isn't it? Please, you have to help us.

The crowd surges forward toward the opening doors. The gore and horror that only just occurred is forgotten in their desperation.

A roiling mass of faces filled with stark fear and determination and bodies jostling for position.

Meanwhile, the ticket drifts unseen, landing silently before another.

Semmelweis: ...?

Yet as Semmelweis reaches out to it, she's met by a shadowy apparition.

Before she can react, the shadow and the ticket are gone, vanishing into thin air.

Semmelweis: A shadow?

Semmelweis: It could be some kind of arcane skill.

The investigator scans the crowd in silence, searching for the source of this "shadow."

Solemn Lady: Annabelle, William, come along. We wouldn't want to get lost now, would we?

Girl: Wait for me, Ms. Dorothy.

Not here.

Convivial Gentleman: A Class 10 steam engine! When this beauty gets goin', it'll run faster 'n the wind blows over the Alps!

Convivial Gentleman: Has a compound engine, you understand? Steam's got to go through two stages 'fore it gets pumped out the top.

Not here, either.

Finding no further clues, her pressing mission returns to the forefront of her mind. She picks up her suitcase and joins the madly churning queue.

Rubuska: Crowd's starting to rush—not safe to stand around.

Rubuska: Excuse me, coming through.

In the brief moment they pass each other, the investigator spots the bloodstained ticket clenched in the boy's hand.

Semmelweis: Please, wait.

He seems not to hear her call, hurrying on as if rushing to board, quickening his pace.

The investigator attempts to stop him, but the boy ducks; her reaching fingers brush across the top of the dark felt hat.

Semmelweis: ...?

Rubuska: Hey, my hat!

The felt hat falls away, revealing a girl's face.

Her hair spills free, drifting in the wind.

Pale skin, red eyes, and fangs—she's the spitting image of a vampire.

Semmelweis: Red eyes ...

The girl bows her head, cutting off the investigator's sight.

Rubuska: Tsk. You're kidding.

Rubuska: I only got that hat three days ago.

Seizing the pause, she leaps into the throng.

In an instant, like a dragonfly into reeds, she disappears into the crowd.

The investigator steps forward to grab her sole piece of evidence—a hat, plain and unremarkable.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: A vampire disguised as a normal person. Though far from perfectly. They could add her picture to the Big Book of Vampire Faces back at headquarters.

If nothing else, it tells her the girl values a clean getaway over her disguise.

Catgut

CH31101-02

The full weight of the earlier travesty finally hits the crowd, as shrieks and shouts of horror divert the attention of even the most desperate.

With one exception—a small and slight figure that darts between the gawking crowd.

Rubuska: Phew. Didn't follow me. Alright, guess I'll just board here.

She exhales, though her hands tremble on her knees.

Rubuska: ...

The adrenaline fades, and rising against it comes the ache of overlong hunger. Her head feels like a weightless balloon.

Rubuska: A little longer yet, Rubuska. There'll be food for days on the train.

Rubuska: All you have to do now is get on.

She presses her belly, slowly straightening.

She slips her hands into her pockets, blending into the line, and glances at the flustered young stewardess.

At the train door, the stewardess spreads her arm, pleading with the agitated crowd.

Train Stewardess: Please wait a moment while our attendant confirms your identity.

Arrogant Passenger: I've waited quite enough, thank you very much. Let me aboard this instant.

Arrogant Passenger: You saw the chaos those peasants raised—a living nightmare, I tell you. And I certainly don't wish to experience it again.

Train Stewardess: I-I understand your concern, Madam Sonya, but we must follow the train's regulations. Now, if you'd just wait a moment longer—

Her face burns red as she stands helpless between passengers and carriage.

Sonya: Hmph! Have you lost your other eye, too?

Sonya: My ticket was snatched by that belligerent fellow who tumbled onto the tracks. Everyone can attest to the fact.

Sonya: Now I beg you to skip all this unnecessary rubbish, else I will be forced to write to the railway administration! I'm sure they'll be very much interested to hear about this little "incident."

Train Stewardess: Please, madam, if you'd just wait for another moment, I'll go and ask my superior.

Despite their difference in size and in station, the little stewardess is able to hold back the agitated woman with a single hand.

Sonya: Hmph! What a crass little girl you are!

???: Aima.

From within comes a woman's voice, deep and grave in its authority.

???: I'll take care of this.

The uniformed woman with a patchwork face approaches the door, a long shadow stretching out behind her.

Rubuska: Wh-Who's that?

On instinct, the girl takes a few cautious steps back, avoiding the frightening visage of this new figure.

Sonya: Oh, don't waste our time. I don't care who explains what's— *gasp* Who—who are you?

???: The solution to your problem.

Sonya: Stitches ... Scars ... Oh! You're that conductress everyone has been talking about.

Sonya: Ahem, as I explained, eh, my ticket has been—

Her shrill tone softens, now touched with nervousness.

Corvus: I've been made aware of this situation. These tickets are made with an arcane process.

Corvus: No one will use your ticket without your consent.

Corvus: Attempts at ticket theft are a familiar thing.

Expressionless, the woman glances into the most unremarkable corner.

Corvus: But we have never lost a single ticket.

Rubuska: ...!

The girl's instinct for danger has never failed her. She turns at once, ready to move ...

Rubuska: Ow!

Her right foot feels weighed down, and she is all at once pulled to the ground.

A faint stinging buzz of electricity flows beneath the girl's feet, as if holding her there.

Rubuska: Ah, that stings. That's her arcane skill?

A thought flashes through her mind.

Rubuska: ...!

One step, two ... the footsteps grow closer.

Corvus: The arcane processing on the ticket will lead us to its location. It's close.

Rubuska: *calming exhale* Okay, stay calm, Rubuska. Nothing to panic over.

Rubuska: Do what you always do. It's worked so far.

She inhales sharply, lips curling into what she hopes is her sweetest, most flattering smile, then turns her head.

Rubuska: Ah, good evening, my fine lady.

Rubuska: ...!

Corvus: Good evening, miss.

Rubuska: I-I'm not feeling so good.

Corvus: Please surrender the ticket. It's in your left trouser pocket.

Rubuska: How do you—Uh, I mean, what ticket, heh?

Corvus: A ticket for the "Danube Dawn." билет за влак, train ticket. Understand?

Corvus: Miss.

Her tone falls like a sledgehammer, pinning her into place.

Rubuska: Alright, alright! I didn't steal it. I just saw it floating in the air, you know, finders keepers and all—

Rubuska: Urgh!

Her body lifts as her collar cinches tight around her throat.

The conductress hoists her up with a disturbing ease.

Rubuska: ...?

She stares in disbelief at her swaying shoes, her emotions struggling to catch up.

Corvus: Aima, take the ticket. It's in—

Aima: Left trouser pocket. I know.

The stewardess approaches with a cheerful smile, reaching a hand toward her waist.

Rubuska: Hey! Hey! Put me down!

Rubuska: Get your hands off me!

Corvus: That mouth has a habit of running off. Should I sew it up for you?

Faint runes shimmer at the tips of the conductress's fingers. The girl wisely clamps her mouth shut.

Aima: Hmm. Coins, a red bottle, a few strips of cloth, and a flute. There certainly is an awful lot in here. Is this some kind of magic pocket?

Rubuska: Hmph.

The stewardess searches the instructed pocket. As she does, she leans in close to whisper in the girl's ear.

Aima: Don't worry, the conductress won't hurt you. We just want to retrieve the ticket.

Aima: Found it. Madam Sonya, please take a look. Is this your ticket?

She gestures to the carriage. A frantic passenger hurries forward and takes the bloodstained ticket.

Sonya: Oh, yes. This is it. Oh, thank goodness you've found it!

The woman cradles it in her palms like a prayer.

Rubuska: ...

The girl falls limp, like a rag caught in the wind.

A few coins, a bottle, some strips of cloth, and a flute. All the possessions to her name.

Her luck has run thin—not that she had much to begin with.

Rubuska: I'm just hungry. So hungry. I never meant to hurt anyone.

Rubuska: Rich people always find a way to get onto these trains. I just thought that maybe I could get on to have a meal.

She swallows her last protest.

Rubuska: You've got your ticket back. So, how about letting me down? I'll see myself off.

???: There you are. What sort of trouble have you gotten up to this time?

A familiar, if unexpected, savior emerges from the crowd.

The dark-haired, dark-eyed investigator strides forward, paying only a passing, if meaningful, glance to the dangling girl.

Semmelweis: Good evening, Conductress. Would you mind letting her down? This is my assistant.

Semmelweis: May I ask what sort of inconvenience she's caused?

She sets the wayward hat back onto the girl's head.

Rubuska: ...?

The girl freezes, then immediately understands. Eyes wide beneath the brim, cheeks flushing red.

Rubuska: That-That's right! I'm Rubuska, her assistant! What took you so long, boss?

Rubuska: I couldn't find you anywhere, what with all the snow ...

Corvus: ...

Corvus lowers her to her feet, studying the two odd figures—so unalike in accent, dress, and bearing.

Corvus: Assistant?

Rubuska: Uh, y-yeah! We're on a very, very important mission, haha. But we got separated.

Semmelweis: We've wasted enough time. Let's go, and don't forget your ticket this time.

A brand-new ticket is pressed into Rubuska's hand.

Once meant for one of the presently missing members of Squad 77, it now belongs to her.

Semmelweis: If you cause trouble like that again, I won't hesitate to punish you, in line with the proper regulations.

Rubuska: Sure, sure. Thank you.

She nods rapidly, clutching it tight, casting the investigator a conflicted glance.

Corvus: I see. In that case ...

Corvus: On behalf of the crew of the "Danube Dawn," I wish you a pleasant journey.

She dips her head, businesslike.

Corvus: We're running late now, and the snow is getting heavier.

Corvus: Come aboard. If there are any other matters to discuss, let us do so in the warmth of the train.

Seating Carriage

Passengers file aboard, excitement in their eyes.

Passenger II: How splendid! This train is more luxurious than I ever imagined!

Hatted Gentleman: Well, she was a luxury express once upon a time. I heard that durin' her golden age, each journey she took was like a social event in itself, filled up to the brim with nobles and celebrities ...

The investigator scans the crowd, but it seems her reinforcements are nowhere to be found.

The communicator remains silent. No reply.

Semmelweis: It appears I'll have to finish this mission myself.

Semmelweis: Heh. It's not all bad. At least I'll have a little bonus waiting for me when I get back to the Foundation.

She offers a soft sigh before turning her sharp glance back to her first catch of the evening—mid-slink in a second escape attempt.

Semmelweis: You're going the wrong direction, Ms. Rubuska. Our seats are this way.

Rubuska: Haha, ha, of course they are.

The girl scratches her head, feigning awkwardness. But her eyes shoot to the investigator's hand now firmly grasping her arm.

Rubuska: Thank you so much, ma'am. I never would've gotten on board if it weren't for you.

Rubuska: I really don't have anything to repay you with, though. Tell you what, when we get to Budapest, if you still remember me—

Semmelweis: Not so fast, Ms. Rubuska. I have some questions for you.

Rubuska: ...

The carriage goes utterly silent despite the commotion of boarding.

She follows the others' eyes now locked on the conductress and stewardess standing together at the end of the carriage.

Corvus: Welcome aboard the "Danube Dawn," operated by Vienna-Pannonian Railways. I am Corvus, your conductress, and this is Aima, your chief stewardess.

Corvus: The "Danube Dawn" travels from Istanbul to Vienna, a journey of a little more than 800 miles, with stops in Nika and Budapest.

Corvus: Due to an unfortunate incident at the station, our departure will be delayed until after dinner while we cooperate with the local government's investigation.

Corvus: As an apology, we have prepared a substantial meal for every passenger.

Rubuska: Free food!

Her eyes flash bright, her stomach quivers with anticipation.

She steadies her trembling fingers and masks her weakness with a smile.

Semmelweis: I see you have a particular interest in food.

The investigator smiles at her.

Semmelweis: You're welcome to my meal, if you'd like.

Semmelweis: But in return, you need to sit here and stay out of trouble. Do we have an agreement?

Rubuska: Well, I mean ... It is tempting, but—

The girl blinks.

Rubuska: Why're you doing all this? I'm just an ordinary girl. Why do all this for me?

Semmelweis: I'm not keeping you, if that's what you're thinking. You're free to go anytime.

She leans closer and lowers her voice with intent.

Semmelweis: That is, if you really are a "normal" girl as you claim.

Semmelweis: That conductress is sharp. If she figures out you're not my assistant, it may be difficult to convince her not to throw you out.

Semmelweis: And to top it off ...

Around them, the rich, the powerful, officers, and writers each settle into their seats, lively chatter filling the carriage with anticipation.

Semmelweis: I don't think this train is anywhere near as safe as it first appears.

Legend's Tale

小径

The "Danube Dawn" — Rumor 1

> The "Danube Dawn" was once the Versailles Palace on rails, gliding along the banks of the Danube River. From Istanbul to Vienna, silverware clinked a harmonious tune, vase violets glistened with dew, and even the stokers carried themselves with the poise of Habsburg courtiers—at least, that is what they believed.
>
> But the glory days didn't last. Once the roar of cannons had grown louder than the whistle, it was abandoned—forgotten in a warehouse.
>
> Later, Vienna-Pannonian Railways pulled the train from the warehouse and refurbished it, stripping away the last threads of velvet and cramming in seats hard enough to turn your back straight. The silver tableware disappeared, French cuisine vanished from the menu, and flavorless beef stew took its place. The train now resembles an aging gentleman in an ill-fitting tuxedo, clinging to the last shreds of his dignity.
>
> And then, there was the missing conductor, Mr. Hermann. With a pale face, hollow eyes, and a drooping mouth, his very presence reeked of morbid neuroticism. His dress, however, was pristine in every aspect: from his uniform to his pocket watch chain aligned perfectly with his buttons, to the gloves which never left his hands—not even while eating. None ever saw him sleep. Like a ghost, by midnight, he would wander the train, inspecting every carriage. The "Danube Dawn" was his home. He knew every passenger's quirks, every worn cushion, every stain on the windows. Or so the passengers claimed—that is, those who remembered him.
>
> One night, three years ago, while passing through a fog-drenched stop near Budapest, the conductor vanished—swallowed by the mist, gone without a trace.
>
> Yet a story still circulates among the passengers: the vampire on the train took him. His body was hidden in one of the cars, and his eyeballs embalmed and nailed to the ceilings of cars one and ten so that even in death, he may keep watch over his beloved train.
>
> Forevermore ...
>
> — UTTU Editor: Verity

Bon Appétit

CH31101-03

Dinner arrives, and the tension eases. They hunch over their trays to eat, drink, and chatter, laughter rising and falling.

Of course, there are a few "incidents."

Sonya: You call this beef stew?

Aima: I truly am sorry, madam. I'm afraid the war has limited our ability to procure supplies up to our usual standards. It may taste slightly different from our usual fare.

Sonya: "Slightly different"? This is boiled cowhide in a thin gruel!

She slams her knife and fork down in anger.

Sonya: It's always "war this" and "war that" with you people. Excuses piled on excuses!

Sonya: I paid my fare, the same as usual; I deserve the service I've come to expect.

Hatted Gentleman: Wouldn't you say that's a touch harsh, ma'am?

Hatted Gentleman: There's people out there gettin' shelled to kingdom come beggin' for any scraps they can get.

Sonya: Hah! Isn't this what you Brits do—stick your noses into a lady's business and levy pointless accusations? Don't you have something better to do with your miserable little life?

Sonya: Perhaps you ought to try feeling the sun on your skin, or, I don't know, cooking a meal that doesn't taste like wet socks?

Arbuthnot: Oh, that's rich, you—

The gentleman flushes red and rises. A stifled giggle sounds behind him.

A woman sits behind them, scribbling purposefully as they speak.

Arbuthnot: What're you doin', ma'am?

???: Me? Just recording what I see.

The editor closes her notebook with grace.

???: "Train Clash: Beef Stew Sparks National Conflict! Lady Accuses British Gent of Abominable Cooking" ...

???: Or perhaps, "Battle at the Dinner Table: One Woman's Rage over Beef Stew."

???: Don't let me stop you. This is all excellent material.

Sonya: Hmph. Journalists ...

Verity: That I am. Though, I'm primarily an editor. But I write reports whenever a good one comes along. Call me Verity.

Verity: If you have any interesting material, especially about arcanists, please contact me. I will pay accordingly.

Arbuthnot & Sonya: ...

The pair falter, unable to reply, and return to their dinner. The quarrel, now soothed, leaves the stewardess effusively grateful.

Aima: Thank you ever so much, madam.

Verity: Don't you worry, poor thing.

The editor props her head in one hand, turning to watch a passenger feasting in the corner.

Verity: At least someone's enjoying the meal.

Rubuska: *munching* I haven't had food like this in *gulp* forever!

The sight of food, real food, melts away the girl's anxieties.

The speed and ferocity with which she eats is startling, yet the investigator spies a curious inconsistency—good table manners.

Rubuska: Thank you, ma'am!

Semmelweis: It's Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: Has anyone ever told you that your eye color is very unique?

Rubuska: Yeah? Uh, thanks.

Rubuska lifts her head, eyes shadowed by her brim—unusual eyes.

Rubuska: You were saying that this train isn't as safe as it looks.

Rubuska: Why'd you say that, exactly?

She presses her hat lower.

Semmelweis: People rarely match their deeds to their words. They may say one thing, but I've found their true motives to often be much darker.

Semmelweis: Anyone could be a danger. The passengers, the conductress, or even ...

Semmelweis: You.

Her tone is not forceful, falling short of accusation, still Rubuska cannot help but make her case.

Rubuska: Ms. Semmelweis, all I am is a hungry kid looking for food. Look at me, how could I be a threat to anyone?

Semmelweis: You did take that woman's train ticket, yes?

Her voice is gentle, but her words piercing.

Rubuska: I ... Well, yeah, I took it.

Rubuska: But, I hadn't eaten anything for four days. I needed to do something to survive.

Rubuska: I didn't mean to do her any harm. I figured maybe they'd let her on anyway, and then we'd both get on, and there'd be no trouble.

The girl flushes red. Semmelweis holds her stare, as if already knowing the truth and waiting for a confession.

At last, she allows a smile to slip from her face.

Semmelweis: No one can blame you for trying to survive in these conditions. At the very least, you weren't the cause of any harm.

Semmelweis: But there is one thing I'm curious about. How did you reach that ticket earlier? It was your arcane skill, wasn't it?

Rubuska: ...

Her silence is the answer. Realizing her slip, she stiffly changes the subject.

Rubuska: "People rarely match their deeds to their words," then, what about you? What are you doing here?

Semmelweis: I'm here to investigate this "duplicity."

She sidesteps the question, producing a folder from her briefcase.

Semmelweis: But our arrangement was for you to answer the questions.

She draws out a white slip of paper.

Semmelweis: Have you seen this pattern before?

Rubuska: Hmm.

Rubuska: Yeah ... Yeah, I've seen it. Maybe in a market? Uh, or, on a wall somewhere.

Rubuska: I might be able to search my memory more carefully, that is, if you let me go later.

The girl eyes the symbol again, as if thinking hard. But the facade drops.

Semmelweis: You're quite clever. Unfortunately, your acting skills could use a little work, which means I already have my answer.

Semmelweis: You're not one of them.

Rubuska: *sigh*

She frowns bluntly.

Semmelweis: One last question. How familiar are you with vampiric legends?

Semmelweis: It's often said that their eyes have a peculiar quality, just like ...

She meets the girl's crimson eyes, catching a flicker of panic.

Rubuska: I-I have no idea what you're talking about.

Corvus: Excuse me, madam. A moment of your time.

A voice cuts the tension. At the far end of the carriage, the conductress raises a hand, beckoning the investigator.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: Stay put. I'll be back soon. Do exactly as a good little assistant would do, understood?

Semmelweis: Vampires aren't the only dangerous things that may lurk on this train.

Rubuska: Sure thing, boss—

After warning her "assistant," the investigator rises and makes her way toward the conductress.

Conductress's Cabin

Corvus: That girl is not your assistant.

Corvus: Save your explanation. I doubt you've known each other for more than half an hour.

The conductress leans against the wall in what must, for her, be a supremely exaggerated gesture.

Semmelweis: I wouldn't have expected you to probe into matters of passenger privacy. I believe we should abide by certain basic humanitarian principles, even during wartime. Wouldn't you agree, Conductress?

Corvus: If you were an ordinary passenger, as you claim, I wouldn't have "probed."

Corvus: But you are from that "Foundation," correct?

Her gaze falls on the badge at the investigator's chest.

Corvus: That badge with the black-and-white print. Wherever the Foundation shows up, trouble follows.

Semmelweis: No need to be nervous, ma'am. I'm just on my way to Vienna for a little holiday.

Corvus: Aboard an express train bound to pass through a war zone—you must take your vacations very seriously.

Semmelweis: ...

The investigator sighs and pulls out her Foundation ID.

Semmelweis: St. Pavlov Foundation. I'm sure you'll find my identification is in order.

Corvus: St. Pavlov Foundation ...

Corvus: Investigator Semmelweis.

The conductress returns the card without a change in tone.

Corvus: I see. Is there anything that I might do for you, Investigator?

Semmelweis: We've received intelligence that there may be a dangerous vampire on this train. I could use your help in the investigation.

She cuts straight to the point, stating her mission boldly and without restraint.

Corvus: A vampire.

A grim shadow passes over the conductress's face.

Corvus: You're chasing fairy stories. If you ask around, all you'll get is a hundred different stories; none of them real.

Corvus: I can't help you chase a myth.

She returns to the sofa, picking up a pair of knitting needles.

Corvus: Please have a seat, Investigator. I hope my handicraft doesn't bother you.

Semmelweis: W-What are you working on?

Corvus: A scarf for Aima.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis steadies herself, forcing her eyes away from the flickering needles.

Semmelweis: I've been tasked with verifying the authenticity of this intelligence. However, your attitude ...

A thought flashes through her mind.

Semmelweis: You mentioned that you've seen this badge and pattern before. Was it someone you met recently?

Corvus: I have worked on the "Danube Dawn" for many years, Investigator. I have seen everything except a vampire.

The conductress lifts her eyes from the tight stitches to meet hers.

Semmelweis: I see.

Semmelweis: Then let's presume you're telling the truth. It's understandable that it would be difficult to imagine something you've never seen.

The investigator leans forward.

Semmelweis: According to our intel, vampires are extremely dangerous creatures. Once bitten, death is a near certainty, regardless of whether the victim is human or arcanist.

Semmelweis: Those few who survive become what is known as "Infected."

Semmelweis: They're like a bomb with a broken fuse, no predicting when they'll go off.

Semmelweis: Therein lies our problem, Conductress. We believe one such vampire is hiding somewhere on this train.

Semmelweis: There's no need to exaggerate the threat this may pose to your passengers. You aren't going to turn a blind eye now, are you?

Corvus: ...

Aima: Conductress, the station staff said they want to confirm something in person with—Huh?

Corvus: The two women sit facing one another, their expressions cold and serious.

Aima: Oh, am I interrupting something important? My apologies, I'll just ...

Corvus: Wait. I'll go with you.

The conductress sets the scarf on the sofa's edge.

Corvus: Excuse me for a moment, Investigator.

Corvus: It's an administrative process for the passenger who fell on the tracks.

"Administrative process." She stresses the words.

Corvus: Let's go. Best not to keep them waiting.

She leaves through the open door, her stewardess trailing behind like a lost duckling.

Semmelweis watches the guards on the platform, studying the movement of their lips.

Platform Guard: Our supervisors need an answer.

Platform Guard: The train can't depart unless ...

Semmelweis: Are they trying to blackmail her? I suppose it isn't unheard of in times of war.

Semmelweis: A long stop could prove helpful to my investigation.

Unexpectedly, the conductress does not resist the guards' demands. Instead, she produces a badge.

Platform Guard: Oh, so you're one of us, hahahahaha.

The standoff ends. A faint smile creeps over Corvus's face.

Semmelweis: Could the railway be working with the army? No, then this conversation wouldn't be happening.

Semmelweis: Is she handing him a badge?

Then, as if sensing her eyes, the conductress suddenly turns to the window.

Corvus: ...

Her smile collapses in an instant.

Semmelweis: Perceptive, aren't you?

She leans back, watching as the conductress and stewardess disappear from view.

On the steps of the train, the conductress halts and waves her hand briskly.

Corvus: Alert the station to begin sanding the tracks. We're departing soon.

Whose Nightmare?

小径

Excerpt from the Vampire Beyond Entity File

File No.: XXX-1912-B (The Beyond - Vampire)

Clearance Level: Top Secret

The vampire is an extremely rare Beyond being bearing a strong resemblance to humans, yet with several defining traits: its skin is notably pale, its irises typically crimson—varying in depth with its tolerance for blood intake. Anatomical studies confirm that blood functions as one of its key energy sources. Vampires exhibit a compulsive craving for blood, particularly that of highly active animals.

Key Traits:

1. Bloodthirst

A vampire's obsession with blood often triggers bouts of extreme aggression and heightened tracking ability (showing acute sensitivity to the scent of blood). However, certain reports suggest blood is not their sole means of sustenance. A rare few can resist Bloodthirst altogether or survive on alternative food sources without dependence on blood.

2. Photophobia

Vampires exhibit a marked physiological aversion to sunlight. Prolonged exposure to strong daylight causes irreversible tissue damage. These entities cast no visible shadows or reflections —whether upon water, glass, mirrors, or polished metal surfaces.

3. Vulnerabilities

Ordinary physical attacks are largely ineffective. Only bullets forged from metals refined

through specific alchemical techniques (most notably pure silver) can inflict permanent injury upon them.

4. Vampire Infected

When a vampire bites or exchanges bodily fluids with an individual possessing innate arcanum affinity, there is a high probability of "conversion."
The infected undergo ■–■ hours of violent physiological and psychological mutation, with a 93% mortality rate and over 96% incidence of mental instability among survivors. Those who endure the process ultimately become "the Infected," gradually gaining the creature's biological traits and mastering its arcane skills.

Note: Intelligence suggests "Manus Vindictae" is conducting ongoing experiments to convert ordinary humans directly into vampires. The success rate and stability of such transformations remain unknown.

Disclaimer

Both vampires and their infected derivatives are officially classified by the Foundation as "the Beyond," distinct from both humans and arcanists.

Last Updated: November 15, 1912

The Midnight Piercer

CH31101-04

With a sharp whistle, the train surges forward, chugging with growing speed into the black expanse.

Rubuska: Phew. The train is finally moving!

Hearts long held in suspense settle, lulled by the rhythmic sway of the train.

Rubuska: Now, what to do when I get to Budapest? First, eat a lot of Kapama!

Rubuska: No, no, wait. First thing's first. Find a job, then Kapama!

Rubuska: ...

Rubuska: Find a job so I can eat Kapama. Eat Kapama so I can work harder.

The girl draws her kaval flute, fingers brushing the tiny cracks.

Rubuska: Мама, will the Kapama in Budapest taste as good as yours?

She looks out at the rolling mountains in the distance, seeing a lone figure running along their spine.

The figure dashes through a graveyard, over cold fields, beneath a sagging sky.

Her silent film is suddenly pierced with sound—a scream that only she can hear.

Rubuska: Whatever happens, I'll do my best to stay alive. I promise, Мама.

The girl sniffles, putting the flute away before taking a quick look around the carriage.

Rubuska: Ms. Semmelweis won't be back for a while, right?

Semmelweis: I'm here to investigate this "duplicity."

Semmelweis: One last question. How familiar are you with vampiric legends?

Semmelweis: Vampires aren't the only dangerous things that may lurk on this train.

Rubuska: She did pay for my beef stew and lark cake, but she seems really obsessed with vampires.

Rubuska: No, the sooner I leave, the better.

She jumps from her seat, hesitates, then drops two coins on the table.

Rubuska: Forgive me, Ms. Semmelweis. I'll repay you, someday! Cross my heart!

Resolute, she turns back, searching for another refuge.

Rubuska: Ouch!

Annabelle: *sob*

Annabelle: I-I'm lost. *hiccup* I can't find my friends.

Rubuska: Uh, I'm sure you'll find them sooner or later! It's not like they were thrown off the train or something.

Rubuska: So, just keep on searching! Go on, you can do it!

The girl hurries to leave, but her hem is caught.

Annabelle: Please help me. *sniffle* I don't know where I am.

Rubuska: ...

Her sobbing echoes so loudly that people three carriages away prick their ears.

At last, she plays her trump card, removing her hat to reveal her fangs and crimson eyes.

Rubuska: S-Stop crying. I'm a vampire. If you don't stop, I'll bite you!

Annabelle: ...

Annabelle: Really?

No fear. No disgust.

Only curiosity. Innocent wonder.

Rubuska: Uh, aren't you afraid of me? I'm a red-eyed vampire. See?

She leans closer, pulling down her eyelids.

Annabelle: Wow! Your eyes are so pretty! Like rubies!

Rubuska: Rubies? Never heard that one before.

She flushes red, caught off guard by the compliment.

Annabelle: Rubies or-or maybe the red roses of Damascus!

Rubuska: Roses? I—Sure they are! Roses that never wither!

Rubuska: Tell me more—more of these good things about vampires.

The girl circles her while jumping up and down like an excited puppy.

Annabelle: But Ms. Dorothy doesn't let us read vampire stories. She says they're, um, made-up-believe. I don't care, though. I think they're amazing, don't you?

Annabelle: So I read them myself. The pure-blooded vampires are the strongest, and they live in big, big castles! You must live in one too, right?

Rubuska: S-Sure I do. Now that you mention it ...

Rubuska: Maybe I can tell you all about my glorious ancestors.

Rubuska coughs lightly, claps her hands, and recounts her proud history.

Rubuska: Ahem. Long, long, long ... a lot of longs ago, back in the earliest times.

Rubuska: A most amazing ancestor of mine gave some invaders a good beating!

Rubuska: Yeah, that's right. He was the famous Impaler, known as Dracula, Arnold, um, Arnold V!

Annabelle: Dracula! Dracula!

Rubuska: My great-grandfather Arnold lived for 155 years! Then he took a wooden stake to the heart and bled to death.

Annabelle: Then, how old are you? Um ...

Rubuska: Name's Rubuska. I'm 14 years old.

Rubuska: Erhm, I'm, I mean, I'm 214 years old.

She quickly corrects herself.

Rubuska: Yep! I've already lived two hundred plus two times seven years.

Rubuska: But I'm still young for a vampire of my lineage.

The young girl speaks with fervor, reciting the stories from memory.

Stories that rise up from the endless snowy winters: silence, a blazing hearth, her head on her mother's lap, eyes drifting shut.

Fangs soaked with blood, moonlit nights, and dark castles ... She begged her mother to tell those wondrous tales again and again.

Until her voice grew faint.

And the little girl drifted into blissful sleep.

???: Vampire?

Children gather as if drawn by unseen magic.

Annabelle: William!

The lone bird finds companions at last.

Annabelle: You're here, hahaha. This is my new friend, Rubuska. She's a vampire!

Child I: Wow, a real-life vampire!

Excited voices fill the air, until a boy steps from the shadows, scorn written on his face.

Little William: How do you know she's a vampire, huh? You don't have any proof.

Child II: Yeah! Does she look anything like the ones in the stories?

Annabelle: She does! Her eyes are red! Like rubies!

Little William: But-But when Uncle Henry was sick, his eyes went all red, and you said he was a vampire too. Remember?

Little William: Ms. Dorothy even scolded us for being rude.

Annabelle: Don't listen to him! You're a real vampire, right, Rubuska?

Rubuska: O-Of course I am!

She flusters, now determined to defend the honor of her kind.

Rubuska: You want proof? Then here it is. I'll show you what a real vampire looks like.

She makes a performance of strolling under the light.

Rubuska: Take a look. Can you find my shadow?

Annabelle: Shadow ...

Child II: Wait, you don't have a shadow!

Shadows accompany every child, an identical twin matching the movement of their hands in the darkness.

But Rubuska stands alone. As if the light itself goes straight through her, as though she was never bound to its law, never part of the world it illuminated.

Rubuska: Exactly! We vampires don't have shadows.

Children: Vampire! Vampire!

The children cheer louder and louder, clapping with glee.

Little William: Whoa! She really is a bone-and-fide vampire!

Rubuska: Told you so.

Her pride is short-lived. Another challenge soon follows.

Child I: So, you're a vampire. Then you must be brave. How about the scary conductress? Have you ever talked to her?

Rubuska: Conductress? Umm, I mean, more than just talk. She's actually one of my best friends.

Rubuska: You think she's scary, huh? I'm telling you, she's big, but she's slow. If it weren't for me ...

The children watch with rapt attention.

Little William: Wow, you're like a boss! Our boss!

Children: Boss! Boss!

She feels almost dizzy with power.

Rubuska: Well, if you insist ... Alright, fine. I'll be your boss.

Corvus: Looks like you're having fun, "best friend."

A rumbling voice cuts through.

Rubuska: Y-You heard all that?

Aima: We heard you the moment we entered the carriage. How wonderful to see you all getting along!

Corvus: "Big but slow," is that right?

Rubuska: Haha, it's just—just a game. Hahahaha.

Corvus: ...

Corvus: Play as you like, but don't block the aisle.

Rubuska: Sure thing, uh, old pal. Hahaha. We'll, uh, make sure we do that.

Aima: Are these your new friends, Ms. Rubuska?

The stewardess examines the gaggle of children surrounding Rubuska.

Rubuska: Not just friends. They're more like, uhm, familiars!

Rubuska: Right, everyone?

Rubuska sniffs, proud of her new "followers."

Annabelle: Exactly! We're the familiars of the great vam—

Rubuska: Ahem, ahem! This place is too crowded. I must have a larger castle, you hear me?

She changes the subject abruptly.

Rubuska: When we get there, I can tell you some more stories about "that."

Annabelle: That? Oh, "that"!

Children: New stories! New stories!

The noise fades, and the carriage returns to calm.

Aima: How lovely it is to see Ms. Rubuska making so many new friends. I'm almost a little jealous.

Corvus: You've never had many friends; is that why?

Aima: I ...

Aima sneaks a glance at her, hesitating.

Aima: Ah, it's about time we headed back. Ms. Semmelweis must be waiting.

Corvus: It is. Let's go.

Before leaving, the stewardess casts a final worried look at the mischievous passenger, remembering her shadowed smile.

And those impossibly brilliant crimson eyes.

Aima: Rubuska ...

Innocence Sealed Away

小径

Annabelle's Diary

> Outside, it's as dark as if someone had spilled a whole bottle of ink. The glass window reflects me and little William sitting opposite each other. I bet he's not really asleep! The kerosene lamp on the table casts our shadows on the wall. I stare at them, hold my breath, and clutch my teddy bear tight.
>
> The train clatters along the rails, like someone's chasing after us, chasing us away from Istanbul, away from Uncle's house. When Ms. Dorothy was packing our clothes, her hands were shaking so much she couldn't even fasten the buttons on my shirt. Her face was pale as paper, lips pressed tight, as if the moment she opened her mouth, all the awful words trapped in her throat would come flying out like crows. She just said, "Children, hurry! Come with me." Everything happened too fast. I didn't even have time to pack all my dolls—Jenny, Jack, Nina ... I'm sorry, I couldn't bring you with me!
>
> Where is this train taking us? Budapest ... Father's home. Will there be a warm fireplace there? Sweet Dobos cake? The smell of roses? I've already forgotten what Father looks like ... but he must be tall ... tall enough to protect us! Like the heroes in bedtime stories ... the powerful, brave, amazing vampires who only appear at night and vanquish everything in their path!
>
> If only ... if only a vampire would really come! They'd drain the blood of all the bad people and protect good children who behave. So they'd surely scare away whatever's hiding in the dark, whatever it is that makes Ms. Dorothy's face go pale.
>
> I keep praying silently, again and again. I believe the great vampire will come to save us!

Four and a Half Friends

CH31101-05

The train rocks as it plows through the winter storm.

The investigator lets her vision glaze over the scene beyond the window, still pondering the meaning of the conductress's badge.

Semmelweis: She handed it over so naturally, as if she had done it countless times.

Semmelweis: Plus, it appears she's encountered someone from the Foundation before. I am forced to conclude that our conductress is hiding something from me.

She pulls a pocket watch from her coat and flicks it open.

Semmelweis: They've been gone for a while now. Well ...

Then she looks around the room.

Thanks to the conductress's fine administrative processes, every file is simple to find.

From timetables to station logs, everything is within reach.

Semmelweis: These files are just sitting out on the table. Do they have no sense of confidentiality?

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: An easily laid clue is often a trap, though. This could be bait. Better act cautiously.

The investigator shakes her head, casting the thought aside.

Corvus: I apologize for keeping you.

Corvus enters and returns to her sofa; her loyal stewardess follows in behind.

She takes stock of the room, confirming that nothing has changed since she left.

Corvus: Aima has placed your luggage at your seat. No need to worry; nothing has ever gone missing from the "Danube Dawn."

Corvus: You've waited for some time. Where were we?

Corvus: The Foundation, your vampire, and this investigation you mentioned.

Semmelweis: To rule out any threat, I need to verify every passenger on board, carriage by carriage.

The investigator shifts tactics, speaking more directly.

Corvus: That would be controversial, especially in the midst of this war. I fear it may cause unnecessary disturbances.

Corvus: I'm sure neither of us would like a repeat of the incident from before.

Semmelweis: I apologize, but my mission parameters are clear. You've misunderstood my intent; this was a notification, not a negotiation.

Corvus: In that case, I will need to see some formal authorization.

Corvus: I won't allow someone to disturb the peace of my passengers just because they claim it to be necessary.

She arches a brow, certain that the investigator doesn't have the authorization.

Semmelweis: I fear that authorization is still little more than a draft on their desk—the "joys of bureaucracy."

Semmelweis: But as you seem to be a fan of red tape, if you refuse to cooperate, regulations state that it is within my power ...

She pauses to draw out the effect.

Semmelweis: To stop the "Danube Dawn."

Corvus: ...

Aima: Stop the train? No.

Semmelweis: Indeed. I am fully within my authority to stop this train at any time to conduct an investigation.

Aima: I understand, but it could inconvenience our passengers.

Semmelweis: Just the passengers?

Aima: ...!

Aima opens her mouth, then closes it again, glancing at the conductress.

Corvus stands and pats her on the shoulder.

Corvus: I see.

Corvus: I have one stipulation that my stewardess and I accompany you during your inspection.

Semmelweis: As you wish. I assure you the process will be carried out with openness and transparency.

Corvus: If the purpose is likewise open and transparent, yes.

Semmelweis: Naturally, Conductress, I have told you everything—as far as I'm permitted, at least.

The investigator maintains a practiced, businesslike smile as she extends her hand.

Semmelweis: There is no time to lose. Let's get started.

Semmelweis: Glad we could come to an agreement, Conductress.

Seating Carriage

Announcements, explanations, records ... their "cooperation" continues smoothly.

Corvus: How many carriages left?

Aima: Um, except the locomotive, the brake van, our compartment, two registered, and this one we're registering ...

Semmelweis: Twelve minus three, then minus two, then minus one.

Semmelweis: Six carriages to go.

Semmelweis answers with a subdued smile.

Dorothy: Conductress, Ms. Aima, I need your help. Two of my students have gone missing.

A worried lady approaches, concern evident on her brow.

Corvus: Please remain calm, madam. How long have they been missing? Could you describe them in detail?

Dorothy: The two of them are about this tall. The little girl always carries a doll with her, and the boy has short, brown curly hair.

Dorothy: I lost sight of them in the dining car about half an hour ago. Seems they've taken this train as some sort of playground.

Aima: Conductress, they sound like the little boy and girl we met just now.

She notes down each description carefully, attentive to all the passengers.

Corvus: Ah, Rubuska's "familiars."

Corvus: Look behind you, madam. Are these your students?

Following the conductress's words, all eyes turn to the children at the back.

Rubuska: After the glorious Count Arnold V came my grandfather Savonovic!

Rubuska: Grandfather Savonovic brought the whole family north of the Danube and built Arges Mill —er, I mean, Arges Castle!

Rubuska: He lived to be 165 years old.

Children: *snore*

The girl eagerly continues her tales, unaware and unconcerned that her audience has drifted off to sleep.

Dorothy: William! Annabelle! You can't go messing about yourselves like this!

The governess storms over, skirt swaying wider than usual, appearing almost like a bowling ball rolling down the aisle.

Annabelle: Mmm. Hm? Ah!

Little William: M-Ms. Dorothy! Uh-oh.

The children jolt awake, Annabelle springing from Rubuska's lap.

Dorothy: Annabelle! You get back here right now! You should know better than to associate with that kind of company.

Dorothy: That goes for you too, William! Come on, quickly!

Rubuska: That ... that kind of company?

Rubuska: Is she talking about me?

From her sharp gaze, Rubuska realizes the difference in their clothes.

A hand lands on her shoulder, breaking her thought.

Corvus: We meet again, "old pal." We're here to register your information if you might spare the time.

Rubuska: If I said I couldn't, would you let me go?

Dorothy: I suggest you do a thorough check on her background. I suspect she could be a trafficker!

Annabelle: No, Ms. Dorothy, I was lost, a-and Rubuska helped me!

Dorothy: How many times have I told you? You are a young lady of a certain stature. It won't do to get too close to this riff-raff.

Rubuska: Riff-raff? Hey, lady, what do you mean?

Aima: A-Apologies, madam, but this is just a simple passenger registration.

Aima: No need to worry, Ms. Rubuska. We just have a few simple questions for you. Let's see. Um, what are you?

Rubuska: I'm Rubuska!

She straightens her back and speaks firmly.

Semmelweis: ...

Aima: Um, sorry, perhaps I wasn't clear. I mean your lineage.

Rubuska: L-Lineage. Oh, sure, I'm Th-Thermanikian.

Corvus: Let's hurry this along. Not your name, nor your place of birth, nor gender.

Corvus: Arcanist or human?

Rubuska: Oh! Um, then, I guess I'm ...

Corvus: There is no third option.

Rubuska: Wow, how do you know? Alright! I, I'm—

The girl falters, eyes dodging, but it's William that leaps to explain.

Little William: She's our vampire boss; of course she's an arcanist.

Dorothy: Silence, William! Who taught you to say such things?

Aima: Oh!

Semmelweis & Corvus: ...

Rubuska: Ha, hahaha, ah, I was just messing around with the kids.

Rubuska: Didn't you ever play make-believe when you were young? Vampires, werewolves, Rusalka ...

Corvus: I did not.

The conductress coldly interrupts her.

Corvus: Given these extraordinary times, I'll ask that there be no more such make-believe on the train.

Rubuska: I won't do it again, I swear.

She exhales, but Annabelle, now awake and confused, speaks up.

Annabelle: But you are a vampire, Rubuska.

The air stills.

Annabelle: You don't have a shadow. You showed us. And real vampires don't have shadows, right?

Annabelle: Vampires are really, really strong, and Rubuska is a good vampire. S-So you should all be nice to her!

She gathers her courage, standing firm even under the governess's glare, her voice quiet but sure as she challenges their attitude.

The crowd looks down to the finely embroidered carpet beneath the girl's feet and fails to find her shadow.

Aima: She's right. She really has no shadow.

Rubuska: Uh-oh.

Corvus: You call this "messing around"?

The patchwork conductress takes a step forward, her towering figure making the children stumble back in fear.

Her hand rests once more on Rubuska's shoulder, firm yet proper.

Corvus: You're going to have to come with us.

Corvus: I'm afraid that "Danube Dawn" security protocol dictates an immediate closed interrogation.

The Suspect's Testimony

CH31101-06

Rubuska: ...

Who are you?

Rubuska: I'm Rubuska.

Rubuska: Are we done? This isn't funny, you know.

What's your purpose on this train?

Rubuska: I'm going to Budapest to find a job.

Rubuska: Let me go.

Do you have any companions aboard?

Rubuska: Hmph, vampires don't team up.

Rubuska: People are too scared of me.

Are you a vampire?

Rubuska: Yeah, I'm a vampire, okay?

Rubuska: But so what? I didn't do anything.

Rubuska: ...

She hangs her head, her whole body radiating defeat.

Semmelweis: She doesn't bear any signs of Manus Vindictae's rituals. She may indeed be innocent.

Semmelweis: But can't rule her out for definite yet. Best to be safe.

Semmelweis returns to the conductress's side.

Semmelweis: I've checked her over. She's not a threat, nor is she my target.

Corvus: Then this isn't any ordinary vampire you're searching for.

Semmelweis: I'm not at liberty to say.

Rubuska: You hear that? She says I'm not a threat!

Soon, she perks up again, a hint of color returning to her face.

Semmelweis: But, according to regulations, dangerous creatures like vampires should be contained in such situations.

Rubuska: Huh?

Semmelweis: It's for the safety of all passengers. A hungry young vampire in an enclosed space like the train is always a risk.

Rubuska: N-No, don't lock me up! I'm not even hungry!

Semmelweis: This is not a request; it's a notification. You've already admitted that you're a vampire.

Rubuska: Vampire, vampire, vampire! Yeah, I'm a vampire, so what?!

Her ruby eyes seem ablaze with fury.

Rubuska: Have I bitten anyone? Have I sucked any blood? Have I hurt even a single person?

Rubuska: I don't understand you people.

Rubuska: Always putting everyone in boxes and then treating them differently just because you put them there! It's like your brains are all square or something!

Rubuska: One minute we're friends, and then the next you're tying me up. All because of these boxes you're so obsessed with.

Rubuska: It's because of these boxes—these stupid labels—that this whole war started. Why I have nowhere to go?

Rubuska: And now you can't wait to do the same to me. Then, fine, go ahead!

Tears begin to streak down her face.

Rubuska: I'm a vampire! Everyone hates me! Go on! What are you waiting for?

Rubuska: Follow your rules! Pierce me through with a stake!

Corvus & Semmelweis: ...

Aima: Goodness, Rubuska, you ...

The carriage is silent for a moment. The passengers stare at the girl as if seeing her anew.

The conductress loosens the strings that bind her.

Corvus: Apologies, we had to tie you up to prevent you from—

Rubuska: Ah-ha! The weakness is revealed.

Rubuska: Take this, pal!

Rubuska: Argh! I didn't even get a good bite in!

Resistance is futile. The conductress pins her down with ease.

Corvus: You're brave.

Corvus: Bold, even.

Corvus: But you're not going anywhere for now.

Rubuska: Let me go! Let me—

Corvus: I'll leave her to you, Investigator. The "Danube Dawn" is not a detention center. We have no obligation to take care of your travel companion.

Semmelweis: ...

A minor nuisance, nothing more.

If it were not for her missing teammates, the investigator wouldn't mind playing chaperone for a day.

Aima: But, perhaps we could offer a personal favor to Ms. Semmelweis?

The stewardess, silent until now, finally speaks with a strange note of eagerness.

Aima: I'm sure I could find an empty room to take care of her, I mean, keep an eye on her.

Corvus: ...

Corvus: The train will arrive at the border checkpoint later today.

Corvus: She can stay with us until then.

Semmelweis lets out a steady, meaningful breath, resigned to this course of action.

Semmelweis: I appreciate your cooperation.

Rubuska: Wait, what about what I think? Where are you taking me?

Sensing the girl's unease, Aima gently takes her hand.

Aima: You can stay in my room, Rubi.

Aima: There's an extra sofa stuffed with goose feathers. It's ever so soft. You're welcome to have a rest there if you're tired.

Rubuska: Rubi?

Rubuska: Come to think of it, that sofa does sound tempting.

Corvus: Call it "house arrest."

Corvus: Allow us to escort you.

The two figures march down the narrow train corridor.

One dangles by her collar, the other nearly scraping the roof. Together, an inseparable, uncanny whole.

Rubuska: Ach, watch it! You're pulling my hair!

Rubuska: I'll bite you! All of you! I swear ...

If you ignore the faintest bit of noise, that is.

The Danube Dawn

CH31101-07

Stewardess's Cabin

Rubuska: This is illegal, you know? Criminal! Let me out.

Rubuska: Let me out.

The girl shouts, pressing her right ear hard against the door, desperate to melt into it.

"Tap, tap ... tap ..."

The footsteps grow fainter, echoing down the empty hallway.

Rubuska: Phew, finally gone. Alright, Rubuska, what's next?

She pulls a metal trinket from her rags and brings it to the lock.

Rubuska: Think this lock'll stop me, eh?

Rubuska: Hmph. You're going to have to try harder than that.

Rubuska: Gotcha!

The door opens, only to a sliver, just wide enough for a ruby eye.

Rubuska: Okay, coast is clear.

Rubuska: Hah. Easy. You've done it again, Rubuska.

She plants her hands on her hips triumphantly, only one more step before freedom.

Aima: Rubi?

Rubuska: ...!

Rubuska: Wh-Where did you come from?

Aima gestures behind her. As the door swings open, the small stewardess is revealed, standing in place.

Rubuska: You, I, uh ...

Caught off guard, Rubi freezes. She doubts her chances to talk her way out of this.

Rubuska: Alright, I'm caught. So, what, you going to report me to your boss?

Aima: Shh ...

The stewardess presses a finger to her lips and winks at Rubuska.

Aima: Be quiet, or they'll hear you.

Aima: Are you afraid? I can smell it on you.

Rubuska: Afraid? *scoff* Clearly you don't know me. So, are you going to tell them or not?

Aima: As long as you don't go running off, I won't.

She checks the hall, then slips inside, delicately closing the door.

Rubuska: So, uh, why are you here? Where's the conductress?

Aima: They're in the brake van. Ms. Semmelweis needs to check over some files.

Aima: Don't worry. Anyway, it's a bit dull all alone in here. Why don't we have a chat? Come, sit next to me.

Aima reclines on the sofa, patting the space beside her.

Rubuska: I ...

The girl glances at her dark palms and ragged cuffs.

Rubuska: My clothes are kind of dirty. I don't wanna mess up your sofa.

Aima: Really, I don't mind.

Rubuska: ...

Warm words don't reach her. She stays rooted to the floor.

Aima: Hmm, then how about ...

The stewardess claps her hands, then seizes Rubuska as if inspired.

Aima: Ah! Let's get you changed! Then you can join me without a worry!

Rubuska: Wait, I didn't—Ah, Lord, you're strong!

Aima: Not this ... or this one ... Ah! Found you!

Aima: Here, put this on!

Rubuska: ...

Aima: Oh my! You look wonderful!

Rubuska: Does it fit?

Aima: Oh, it fits you splendidly!

Aima: I hereby declare that these clothes are yours to keep!

Rubuska: R-Really?

God knows how long it's been since she's worn clean clothes.

Red-and-white stitching traces arcs across the hem of her skirt.

She chokes back words, trying to believe what she sees.

Rubuska: Thank you, Aima.

Rubuska: Hold on, why don't you have a mirror in your room? You've got so many clothes.

The stewardess shyly touches her eyepatch.

Aima: Oh, I don't much like mirrors. My eyes aren't very pretty.

Rubuska: What're you talking about?! You, I mean, your eyes, um, eye looks good—more than good! You're ...

Rubuska: Well, in short, you're good through and through!

She scratches her head, gaze sliding to the pile of garments stacked nearby.

Rubuska: I used to have a closet like yours, filled with silks, cashmere, corduroy ... All kinds.

Rubuska: Did you buy all these clothes yourself?

Aima: Oh, no. Most of them are from a family member.

Aima: He said that life as a stewardess is as boring as our uniforms, so whenever he goes off on a long trip, he buys me new clothes.

Aima: That way, no matter how far apart we are, I always feel like he's right here with me.

Rubuska: Family. Pft, boring! By the time I was your age, I'd already been halfway around the peninsula all by myself.

Aima: Haha, goodness, that sounds wonderful! But I think my life is rather pleasant too.

Aima: Every day the train welcomes new passengers, all bringing their own stories. I can "travel" without ever having to leave.

Aima: And the conductress looks after us. I know she seems stern and maybe a little angry, but she's truly lovely underneath, and a wonderful tailor too!

She points to the row of matryoshkas by the window.

Aima: See the clothes on the matryoshkas? She made every single one. Aren't they darling?

Each wears a colorful knit sweater, their smiles stiff yet harmless.

Rubuska: ...

Rubuska: Wait, sorry. Are there two conductresses on this train?

Rubuska: I mean, I just, no, I can't picture it at all.

Rubuska jerks her head, attempting to banish the uncanny image.

Rubuska: That conductress? Knitting little sweaters?

Rubuska: *shudder* Just imagining it is giving me the creeps.

Corvus: ...

Semmelweis: Conductress, you dropped this.

A ball of red yarn rolls to Semmelweis's feet.

She picks it up, handing it back to the conductress.

Corvus: Thank you. All the files are here. Logbook's in the first drawer on the left; shift handover logs are at the bottom of the second drawer on the right; dispatch instructions are on the table.

Semmelweis: Much appreciated. Thank you again for your cooperation.

Without a word, Corvus resumes her handiwork; the scarf billows out with every stitch, keeping silent company.

A rare moment of peace. Perhaps a chance to understand each other.

Semmelweis: The stitching on this is immaculate. I'm surprised to see you're fond of needlework.

Corvus: It's a common skill, nothing special.

Blunt words, blunt endings. The topic dies.

The investigator returns to her files, scanning endless logs and numbers until she finds another opening.

Semmelweis: The name of this train is very intriguing to me. The "Danube Dawn" ... Does it hold any special meaning?

Corvus: ...

The carriage hums with the grinding of wheels.

Another topic dies.

Semmelweis: Sorry. I've never been much good at small talk or knowing when it's appropriate or with whom ...

Corvus: To unite all regions along the Danube.

Semmelweis: ...?

Corvus: You asked if it meant something.

She pauses her work to meet the investigator's eyes.

Corvus: It's simple: Unite all regions along the Danube, and ...

Corvus: Move forward into the new day as one.

Rubuska: Unite all regions?

Elsewhere, two girls lean against one another on a plush sofa, feeling the rhythmic tremor of the wheels beneath them.

Aima: From Istanbul to Vienna, through Belgrade, Nika, and Budapest ...

Fingers trace lazy lines through the air.

Aima: See how the train is like a line connecting all the dots along the Danube?

Rubuska: Huh. Makes the war seem even more ironic.

Aima: Well, I don't really understand all that's going on out there.

Aima: But I do know that I like this name. The "Danube Dawn"—it sounds warm and bright, like we're all a big family.

Aima: What you said earlier about putting people in boxes—I feel the same way. Why can't they just sit down and have a good chat, like we're doing now?

Rubuska brightens.

Rubuska: I know, right? Haha, I knew we'd get along!

Aima: Of course! I get along with all types. Humans, arcanists, vampires ...

She makes a sly glance toward Rubuska.

Aima: Actually, you're the first vampire I've ever met. It's a little strange and new, but I'm not scared. I like you.

Rubuska: Hah, yeah! You're not so bad yourself. But, is there actually anyone you don't like?

The stewardess tilts her head back in deep thought.

Aima: Hmm, I can't think of anyone.

Rubuska: Hmph, knew it. You like everyone, and everyone likes you. Like a happy little princess.

The "princess" nods, graciously accepting her teasing.

Aima: I'm grateful for the life I'm living, and I hope you are too.

Aima: My only wish is that everyone could live together peacefully.

She clasps Rubuska's hand.

Aima: Like this, see—

Aima: Our fingers are born separate and alone.

Aima: But if we lock them together, they become one. Nothing can break them apart.

Rubuska: Pft, no, they don't. I could break free anytime I want, oh.

The girl recoils slightly, but Aima's grip holds, gentle yet firm.

Aima: Do you want to break free, Rubi?

Rubuska: I ...

Her pale hands are nearly translucent, faint blue veins showing through.

Palm to palm, those threads intertwine, binding them.

Rubuska: ...

Semmelweis: Unite together and move into a new day as one? That's a truly unimaginable concept.

Dream though it was, the spirit of the times brought many who believed it could be real,

wanting to believe the lands along the Danube could live as one.

Semmelweis: Idealism does often come hand in hand with impracticality.

Semmelweis: Still, it's admirable to stand firm in your beliefs. Impractical or not, I respect it.

Corvus: ...

Her unexpected approval is met with an equally strange curiosity.

Her needles continue their motion. With her left hand, she loops the yarn over the right needle's tip, then deftly draws it back down.

Each pull tightens the fabric, fortress walls forming beneath her fingers.

When she speaks again, her voice has softened.

Corvus: It's no difference to me. This is only a job.

Corvus: Deliver thirteen carriages and our passengers from one point to another safely. That's it.

Semmelweis: Thirteen carriages? Are you sure?

The investigator catches the crucial number.

Semmelweis: Seems unusual to choose an unlucky number for a train.

The needle halts.

Corvus: I meant ... including the locomotive.

Corvus: "Rolling stock," then? I didn't want to be too technical.

Semmelweis: It's fine, really. I suppose I should wish you luck, Conductress.

Semmelweis: After all, it is our common goal to have the train arrive safely, yes?

Corvus: Which is why you've been allowed access here. Now ...

The last stitch done, Corvus sets her work aside.

A soft red scarf now rests in her lap.

Semmelweis: It's a beautiful scarf. I'm sure Aima will appreciate it.

Corvus: Thank you.

A flicker of a smile.

Her gaze slips to the clock, checking the time.

Corvus: Have you made any progress?

Semmelweis: Not much, but I did find something helpful—the ticket reservation log. Could be useful to cross-check against what our passengers said.

She nods.

Corvus: Good. We've been here long enough.

Corvus: If you'll excuse me, I have a job to do.

Semmelweis: It's been a pleasure working with you, Conductress.

Together, they rise and step out.

A blizzard rages outside, buffeting the train as it speeds into the night.

News or Rumor?

小径

Notice of the "Danube Dawn" Resumed Service - Vienna-Pannonian Railways

> Vienna-Pannonian Railways announced yesterday that after a full year of maintenance, the "Danube Dawn" will officially resume service next Wednesday. The new train is said to

drastically reduce travel time between Istanbul and Vienna, strengthening connections throughout the Danube region.

Rumors, of course, soon followed. An engineer—who wished to remain anonymous—claimed that the train's remarkable performance might not be entirely due to human work. He reported glimpsing peculiar, Critter-like entities near the engine room and wheel bearings, somewhere between a beetle and a firefly in size, dark brown in color, with two slender antennae that glowed faintly red. The workers nicknamed them "Scarlet Nightmares."

"They seem... very fond of staying close to the engines," he said. "When the machinery runs smoothly, they're lively; when it doesn't, they bunch together and start ... glowing, bright red."

Vienna-Pannonian Railways declined to comment. However, several arcanobiology enthusiasts have suggested that these beings are far from ordinary Critters. They might, in fact, be familiars of vampires—social, volatile creatures said to feed on the blood of laborers.

"This isn't a metaphor," they insisted. "It's real."

"People have long said the disappearance of the 'Danube Dawn''s former conductor was connected to a vampire. Now these Critters show up, and somehow it's the same story again ... maybe the train itself is a familiar of the vampires ..."
"Hah! If tickets weren't sold out, I'd get on board myself, maybe even catch a few to show everyone!"
"Don't joke about that ..."

...

Whether the so-called "vampire familiar theory" holds any truth or not, the "Danube Dawn" will depart on schedule. Will it truly reshape the Danube region's transport network as promised by Vienna-Pannonian Railways? Has it truly been touched by supernatural power? Only time will tell.

The Railway Cat

CH31101-08

Seating Carriage

The hour is late and the lamps dim. Passengers return to their compartments one by one, the soft sway of the train soothing them to sleep like a lullaby.

Only two passengers remain in the shared space, seated face-to-face in silence.

Semmelweis: ...

Verity: ...

Semmelweis: Madam, would you mind putting down your pen? I need to take your information.

Verity: Verity, British, arcanist. I like coffee, battered cod, and breezy nights.

Verity: I hate deadlines and rainy days.

Verity: There. That's all there is to know about me. Now it's my turn to ask the questions.

The editor sets down her pen then leans deep, as if passing along a secret.

Verity: Have you found it?

Semmelweis: I don't know what you're talking about.

Verity: Hah. Well, that's a "no," then.

She waves her hand halfheartedly.

Verity: No matter. I'm sure even the most compelling of stories would turn to a dull report when put in your hands.

Verity: Goodbye. Best of luck with your work.

Semmelweis closes her pen and files, but the editor, struck by a thought, speaks again.

Verity: Ah, but since you've been looking so diligently, I suppose I might throw you a bone.

Semmelweis: Yes?

She leans closer still, giving a wink to the investigator.

Verity: Rumor is many passengers aboard this train have heard crying during the night.

Semmelweis: Crying? What kind of crying?

Verity: Hmm ...

Verity: It starts soft, then turns to a hissing sound, lasting, echoing, and then, all of a sudden, it stops.

She grips her own throat, smiling at the investigator.

Verity: Like a kitten being strangled.

Semmelweis: ...

Verity: Well? How did you like my little ghost story?

Semmelweis: Wait, there's something behind you, hanging in midair. It looks like a strangled kitten.

Expressionless, Semmelweis shuts down the clumsy joke.

Verity: *chuckle* A good attempt, really. But not nearly enough to work on me.

The editor straightens but doesn't shed her smile.

Verity: Back to your work then, Little Miss Clueless.

The registration is finally done.

Feeling a trace of fatigue, Semmelweis returns to her seat and opens her files to review.

Semmelweis: One of the few trains that travels across the peninsula ...

Semmelweis: A crew with as of yet unidentified backgrounds and a haunted carriage ...

Semmelweis: All passengers on the manifest have been registered. No notable discrepancies to be found.

She stows the papers.

Everything falls into place too neatly, every absurdity justified, but something is off.

Semmelweis: And still no sign of the Manus. It seems the key to all this lies with the conductress.

Semmelweis: What is she hiding?

Semmelweis: We're stopping?

Passenger II: Excuse me, sir. Why is the train stopping? I'd just gotten to sleep.

The steward hurries through the corridor, calming the roused passengers.

Train Steward: Apologies for the interruption. I'm afraid the train must come to a temporary stop.

Train Steward: The rail ahead is impassable because of the heavy snow.

Train Steward: The situation is being dealt with as we speak. Please stay in your rooms and remain calm.

Train Steward: The dining carriage will come round to deliver nighttime desserts. We have Leipzig lark cake and Turkish delight. Should you require anything else, please let me know.

Semmelweis: Snow?

She lifts a corner of the curtain.

Snowflakes drift outside, brushed about lazily in the waning storm.

Semmelweis: Snow indeed, but it hardly seems heavy enough to warrant a stop.

On the other side of the train, the little vampire remains fast asleep.

Stewardess's Cabin

Rubuska: *gentle breathing*

Rubuska lies sprawled on the sofa, breathing evenly.

The day's turbulence has worn her down. A new friend's comfort was the best lullaby.

Aima: How odd. I've never known a vampire to sleep at night.

Aima: ...

She reaches out, inching toward the sleeping face.

Aima: Oh, it's time.

The stewardess shakes her head, brushing the hair from the girl's cheek.

Aima: Look at the smile on her face. She must be having sweet dreams. It's a shame I have to go.

She rises and quietly closes the door.

Light fades into shadow until the room is swallowed in darkness.

Aima: Nighty-night, Rubi.

Temporary Stop

The air reeks of damp wood, rot, snow, and conspiracy. A girl drifts among the trees like a phantom, fading into and then reappearing in the dark.

The conductress has been waiting in the snow, crushing flakes in her palm.

Corvus: You're late. Did something happen?

Aima: N-No. S-Sorry, I was just making sure the vampire girl was asleep.

Corvus: Did anyone see you?

The train, the forest, and the winter winds conspire in gray silence.

Snow falls calmly but steadily.

Aima: I was careful. No one saw me.

Corvus: Good.

Corvus: They're expecting us.

The two move toward the rear of the train, vanishing into the heavy snow.

Snow prints follow, another figure trailing them.

Semmelweis: Just as I thought.

Measured Words

小径

Passenger Information Log

…

Sonya, 60 years old
A noblewoman, sharp-tongued and fussy, seemingly fleeing from the war.
Sixty years of pride might have made it hard for her to face reality.

She was supposed to travel with her butler, but tickets for the "Danube Dawn" were nearly impossible to get.
It seems war treats nobles and commoners alike, or perhaps her family's status isn't quite as lofty as she makes it seem.

After ten minutes of complaining about having to travel alone, with no butler to set her table or press the creases from her skirt, she finally boarded by herself.
Do people really spend their whole lives learning to place their cutlery at a perfect forty-five-degree angle? In any case, she's the archetype of a noblewoman straight out of an oil painting, gown in hand. Let's hope that on her road of escape, she learns what the world is really like.

……

…

Arbuthnot, 45 years old
Middle class. A decent, respectable gentleman.
Nothing remarkable about his demeanor—just an ordinary man who fits neatly into his social standing.

A businessman with investments in Eastern European railways and oil.
Vital infrastructure and strategic resources. He's well-connected and has an eye for opportunity.

The war cost him dearly, and he worries for his future.
Special times demand special measures. What troubles him isn't death or hunger—it's the thought of losing a life of luxury forever.

……

…

Do Not Enter

CH31101-09

Nearby Forest, Temporary Stop

Corvus: Apologies for the wait.

???: Lower your weapons. It's Iglika!

Shadows part, young men emerge. Recognizing the conductress, they lower their rifles.

Corvus: I prefer Corvus. It's more familiar to me.

Corvus: Are they all our people?

She checks their faces, easing only when she sees no strangers among them.

Watch Soldier: Yes, no others, just as planned.

Watch Soldier: Pyrrhos's men are patrolling ahead.

Corvus: Good. Finish this quickly.

Corvus: The passengers believe we're clearing snow ahead of the train.

Corvus: Is Pyrrhos holding up his end?

Watch Soldier: Yes. He'll let you through when the train arrives.

Corvus: Good. And the "cargo"?

Watch Soldier: In the carriage over there, in the woods.

Watch Soldier: We've got horses to pull it over.

Watch Soldier: This way. It'll keep you out of sight.

At her word, the men hurry down the forked path by the tracks.

Watch Soldier: Come on, follow us!

She steps forward, but her coat hem is tugged.

Aima: Conductress, I ...

Corvus: Got it.

Corvus: Don't worry. I'll be back.

The conductress drapes a newly-made scarf over the girl's shoulders until it has all but buried her face.

Aima: ...

Aima: So soft. Thank you, Conductress.

Corvus: I don't want you to catch a chill.

Watch Soldier: Iglika—

Patting her shoulder, she walks alone into the shadows.

Watch Soldier: One, two, three!

Watch Soldier: Phew! Done. That was a heavy one.

Corvus: Alright, time for an inventory check.

Semmelweis: She's added another carriage?

Semmelweis blends into the dark shadows of the trees, examining the train.

A new carriage is pulled up and secretly attached behind the rear cabin.

Semmelweis: What's it carrying? Guns? Ammunition? Controlled substances?

Semmelweis: And those don't look like Serbian troops.

She waits until the soldiers disperse, leaving only two behind.

Aima: ...

Aima lowers her head and clutches her scarf.

Then, she suddenly collapses to her knees.

Corvus: Aima?

The snow falls constantly and heavily.

Their figures lean together in the storm, like ghosts rooted among the trees.

In that moment, all else melts away. The world is only the two of them.

Aima: I'm sorry, I ...

Corvus: Shh-shh. I know. I know.

Corvus: Silly girl. Shouldn't have gotten so close.

Semmelweis: What are they ... Could it be ...

The investigator, hidden in shadow, frowns as she keens her eyes.

Semmelweis: Need to get confirmation.

???: Freeze.

???: Hands up where I can see them.

Semmelweis: ...

She raises her hands.

???: Turn around.

Two soldiers stagger before her, faces ghostly and haggard, like two white flames drifting in the night.

Patrol Soldier II: Good. Don't do anything stupid.

Patrol Soldier II: What did you see just now?

Semmelweis: I saw ...

She flicks her toe, kicking a stone into one soldier's knee.

Patrol Soldier I: Ugh!

He cries out, buckling to the ground.

She lunges, seizing his weapon in the same instant, turning it on the other.

Semmelweis: My turn now.

Semmelweis: Hands up where I can see them.

Two young soldiers lie unconscious in the snow.

Semmelweis: Something's wrong with these soldiers. Slow movements, unsteady steps, and their faces ... oddly pale ...

Semmelweis: Hmm, no bullets in either gun. That can't just be a mistake.

She checks their gear: empty rifles, unmarked tags, and a trinket that draws her eye.

Semmelweis: ...!

Semmelweis: Same shape and size. This looks to be the item the conductress gave that soldier at the station earlier.

Semmelweis: Manus Vindictae. Finally, you rear your head.

She runs her fingers over the familiar symbol, then pulls her communicator from her coat and presses the button.

Semmelweis: Investigator Semmelweis to Foundation, mission number 0073-MV.

Foundation Operator: Go ahead, Investigator.

Semmelweis: Progress update: I've found a Manus Vindictae insignia on a soldier at a station near Belgrade.

Semmelweis: The conductress of the "Danube Dawn" has undertaken suspicious dealings with these soldiers, stopping the train on the pretext of "the railway being blocked by the snow" in order to secretly add an additional carriage.

Semmelweis: I now have reason to believe that the conductress is collaborating with Manus Vindictae. Whatever's in that carriage may be related to our blood-sucking target.

Semmelweis: One more thing: I've lost contact with all members of Squad 77.

Foundation Operator: Mission 0073-MV report received. We will continue our search for Squad 77. Please proceed with your mission, Investigator.

Report finished, she snaps the device shut.

She looks up at the dark sky. The storm is easing.

Semmelweis: Been out here a while. Any longer and I might start to raise suspicion.

Semmelweis: Time to head back.

Time passes slowly.

A few passengers stir awake with the stop; some step out of their cabins, whispering in the darkness.

Train Steward: All passengers, please remain in your rooms. The train is about to depart, and we will reach the border checkpoint soon!

The steward moves between cars, calming their unease.

Between two cars, he sees one door ajar, wind blowing snow inside.

Train Steward: Hm? Why is the door open?

Train Steward: Wait a minute, there's something underneath.

Unwell Passenger: *coughing*

A passenger leans there, coughing hard, drawing the attention of the steward.

Unwell Passenger: *cough* Excuse me, when is the train leaving?

Train Steward: Oh! Apologies, sir. In about five, no, ten minutes.

Unwell Passenger: Okay.

He lowers his head with dejection.

When the steward leaves, his eyes roll, lips twitching with a guttural rasp.

groan

Low rumbles drown voices, shouts, any stray sound in the train.

The "Danube Dawn" rolls on into the storm, laden with passengers.

Among the Dead · 1/2

CH31101-10

Among the Dead

I always have the same dream, a dream where time stands still. People never grow old, and the sunshine never fades.

Because there, I can hear Мама's voice again.

Mother: My, look how long your hair has grown, Rubuska.

Mother: Sit up for a moment so I can comb it for you. My hair was just like yours when I was a girl. I do worry when I comb Nikola's, though. His hair's like your father's, all curly at the root.

Young Rubuska: Come on, Мама, please keep telling the story! "In the light of the blood moon, they rise ..."

Mother: "In the light of the blood moon, they rise and stride under the veil of night."

Mother: "Freely, they live, without fear of death."

Mother: "For through blood they live forevermore."

Young Rubuska: Through blood they live ...

Young Rubuska: Amazing! What about me, Мама? What about me?

Mother: You, well, you are our dearest Rubuska, one of the youngest vampires in the family.

Mother: Seasons changed, years passed, and you've spent 214 years, four months, and two days in a deep, deep sleep.

Mother: Now, the people suffering from the war cry out, "Rubuska! Awaken! Open up your scarlet eyes and help us!"

Young Rubuska: Hmm, ah! Is that blood I smell?

Young Rubuska: Now, the great vampire Rubuska has awoken from her endless sleep.

Young Rubuska: Does anyone dare hurt my family? Never fear, Мама. Rubuska's here to bite their necks and suck their blood.

Mother: Hah hah, you silly thing.

Mother: Have you forgotten? As vampires, we're not afraid of anything. Not even ...

Mother: ... death ...

Mother: Run, Buska, RUN!

Young Rubuska: Мама! No, no, I, no, no ...

Mother: Buska, RUN!

A "Song" Without an Owner

小径

The "Danube Dawn" — Rumor 2

Passengers from Car No. 3 often come to me with their troubles—not over the tasteless stew or the unbearably chilly nights, but a sound: a crying that seeps through the partitions and burrows straight into the brain. It feels as if the train itself has come alive, endlessly recounting all the pain its body has endured through the years.

And so, tonight at 11:51 p.m., I went to Car No. 3, sat by the window, and quietly waited for the "cry" to come.

When the hour and minute hands aligned, I heard it—that delicate, indescribable rhythm. The tone rose and fell, turning in on itself, resonating at a frequency barely perceptible. To me, it was more like a ... song, one that no throat could ever produce—something primal, pure, flowing unconsciously from the soul.

Once the word "song" took shape in my mind, it stirred a memory. Along the Danube, there is an old legend of "the Song of the Spirit." They say it is the most beautiful melody ever

imagined by humankind, able to pass through any physical barrier and reach the listener's innermost consciousness.

Could what I heard be that very song? Or was it the faint cry for help from the frail former conductor, Hermann, his decayed vocal cords vibrating through some supernatural force?

Then, without the slightest warning, the singing stopped.

The carriage sank into an absolute, suffocating silence … as though the "Danube Dawn" itself, along with every living and dead thing within its belly, was holding its breath … waiting for an unseen baton to fall again, or for whatever the song had briefly subdued … to reawaken.

— UTTU Editor: Verity

Call of the Blood Moon

小径

Nameless Nursery Rhyme

Listen, the wind is wailing in the distance.
Look, the crimson moon is rising into the sky.
Child, don't linger here.
Don't touch the berries wet with dew.
For that tempting red hue
already carries the smell of rust.

…

Listen, the wind weaves endlessly through the forest.
Look, the bloodthirsty heralds wander here, their forms faint and shapeless.
They have no hearts, no shadows, no bodies,
only blood-red lips, blood-red eyes, and blood-red fangs.
They will use those fangs to suck your little fingers,
as if they were the ripest berries …

Among the Dead · 2/2

CH31101-10

I ran and ran, away from the gunshots, away from another burning village.

I ran into the mountains. They protected me—hid my escape. Then I went to the cemetery.

Young Rubuska: No, no one's following.

Young Rubuska: They can't find me anymore, hahaha.

I found an old coffin, cast aside, forgotten, just there, abandoned by the whole world.

I huddled up inside it, and I lived there. Lived with the worms.

Young Rubuska: It smells like them.

Young Rubuska: Like my "family."

Мама once said that, in this land, the dead never truly die.

She said that our bodies merged with the earth, our blood seeping into the dirt and nourishing the tangled roots of the trees.

And ever so quietly, we'd day by day become one with the world.

So, I wasn't afraid—didn't struggle anymore. I closed my eyes—let the smell wash over me—and a warmth grew in my heart.

Young Rubuska: Dad ... Мама ...

We were together again.

Together again.

Together again, together again.

Rubuska: ...!

She awakens from a dream.

Rubuska: *panting* J-Just a dream.

Rubuska: *deep breath* Just a dream.

Rubuska takes a deep breath, swallowing her tangled emotions.

She looks around. The room is empty.

Rubuska: Can't remember the last time I had a good night's sleep.

Rubuska: Huh, I must have slept longer than I thought. Oh, but that means we'll be getting to the checkpoint soon.

Rubuska: Aima's gone too. Wait. That means I've got a chance to get out of here.

She takes no time to pick the lock again, peeking out like a wary cat.

Rubuska: Yes! No one outside, either.

But before she steps out, she notices her dirty hands, a poor contrast with her fine new dress.

Covered in dust from all her scrambling, she tries to pull down her sleeve, then hesitates, afraid to stain the fine fabric.

Rubuska: Oh, I'd better change.

Rubuska: Just have to put this all back, and ...

Her new clothes are left folded on the sofa. After a pause, she sets her hat beside them.

Rubuska: This is the most expensive thing I own. Take it as my gift.

Rubuska: Bye-bye, princess.

The young vampire slips through the carriages.

Most passengers remain asleep. The night is freeing, yet oddly lonely.

Rubuska: Hmm. Quiet.

Rubuska: Nobody's around now. Then I can have some fun by myself.

She lifts her flute, letting notes keep her company.

Rubuska: Just like the old days.

A soft tone escapes, low and sweet.

Rubuska: Right, here I am in carriage one.

Rubuska: Carriage number two.

One note falls, another rises.

She drifts lightly through the carriage like a passing breeze.

Rubuska: Eleven ...

Rubuska: Huh?

Rubuska: Shouldn't there be twelve carriages? Ten for passengers, plus the brake van and the staff compartment. Yeah.

Rubuska: Then how did this extra carriage get here?

A new carriage, one she's never seen before, rattles in the dark.

But the train stretches long, and in the night it almost feels endless.

Verity: Hmm. What a pretty song. I could almost applaud.

A voice cuts coldly from the shadows.

Rubuska: Oh, you're that lady from before.

Rubuska: I'm counting how many carriages there are. This helps me with it.

Verity: An interesting little game. From your hometown, I presume?

She shakes her head.

Rubuska: No, I came up with it myself.

Rubuska: My hometown's big, you see—so big you couldn't even imagine it.

Climb one mountain, and another rises. Cross one river, and another follows.

The sky stretches endless and gray, a road without end.

Rubuska: Lucky for me, my mother gave me this kaval.

Rubuska: So, I used it to name every mountain and river by giving them each their own note.

She grips her flute with pride.

Rubuska: And now I never get lost!

Verity: Are you certain?

The editor looks up from her scratchy notes, her eyes alight with interest.

Verity: I've heard the carriages on this train can multiply. Even if you played the entirety of Bach's Mass in B Minor, you'd never count them all.

Verity: Go ahead if you don't believe me. You'll see soon enough.

Verity offers a wistful smile.

Rubuska: Oh. What?

She looks down the corridor.

The carriage sways lazily, as if beckoning her forward.

Moonlight peeks through the clouds, pale and cold, shrouding the scene like a white burial sheet, hiding all secrets beneath it.

And there, in a carriage that never was, in that place that shouldn't even have existed, blood-red eyes blinked in the darkness.

And the blood of those sorry passengers trickled, sweet and warm, into the throats of the red-eyed monsters.

Rubuska: ...

Rubuska: Uh, ma'am, I think we'd better stick together.

She steps back in fear, turning to find nothing there.

Just an old iron door, swaying by itself, its hinges groaning, creak ... creak ...

Rubuska: Ma'am?

Rubuska: ...

The girl has no choice but to face the darkness before her.

Rubuska: C-Come on now. You're Rubuska! The blood-sucking vampire! You're not scared of ... *tremble* ... anything.

She takes a deep breath and takes a brave leap.

A heavy copper lock clamps the front door of the carriage, glinting coldly under the moonlight.

Rubuska: Oh. Locked again?

Rubuska: Fine, then I'll just unlock this one too.

Rubuska: Open sesame!

Just one push, and she could slip inside.

Rubuska freezes. Holding her breath, she presses against the door, catching faint sounds from within.

"On one such night, a group of passengers awoke to the sound of crying. They followed it. Then the crying turned to bawling, and the bawling to wailing, until they reached it—"

"A door that wasn't there before."

Fear creeps over her. She turns to leave when a sharp gust throws the door wide open.

Rubuska: ...!

The ancient groan of the door could wake anyone—or anything—long asleep.

Slowly, she lifts her head to face the darkness.

Rubuska: Ahh!

Eyes flicker in the dark, like ghostly flames gathering in the night.

Rubuska: Ugh, ahh! Mmff.

Before she can scream, a hand clamps her mouth, dragging her into the eclipsing shadows.

Carriage No. 13

CH31101-11

Rubuska: *muffled* Mmff. Get off me!

Deep Voice: Alright, she's down! Bring the garlic, stake, and salt!

Heavy hands cover her face, coal smoke, garlic, and earth choking her breath until she nearly faints.

Rubuska: Ugh! What're you ... *chomp*

Urgent Voice: Careful, Yakov! Don't let her bite you!

Finally, the grip loosens. She scrambles to her feet.

The Extra Carriage

Her eyes adjust to the dark.

No vampires, no bats, no endless corridors, just an ordinary, if grim, old carriage.

Dozens of filthy "passengers" crowd together, ragged and tense, clutching makeshift weapons: iron rods, pans, even garlic and salt.

Yakov: Wait, it's just a kid. You're not a vampire, are you, young lady?

Rubuska: Course I am! You're looking at the heir of Dracula the Impaler himself!

They raise their "weapons" once more.

Rubuska: Whoa, whoa, whoa! Let's not be too hasty. This vampire's already got a full belly.

Rubuska: For now.

Yakov: Then tell us why you broke in here. And don't go telling lies.

Rubuska: I ...

Rubuska tries to step back, but the cold iron door blocks her retreat.

Stowaway Passenger: Cut her some slack, Yakov. I don't think she meant any harm.

A woman's voice calls out, gentle but firm.

Yakov: Hmph. Reyhan, every time we try to act tough, you go soft on us.

Reyhan: Maybe so, but what other option do we have? If anyone hears us and comes looking, we're done for.

Rubuska: Sh-She's right. Let me go, and I won't say a word. I-I didn't see a thing, promise.

???: Ugh ... *cough*

A child whimpers in her arms, and Rubuska hesitates.

The woman hugs him closer, soothing him.

Reyhan: It's alright, Ivanushka. No need to be afraid. We've got our eyes on her.

Ivanushka: I'm not afraid. She isn't half as scary as those whizz-bangs.

The boy leans against the woman, one sleeve hanging empty.

Ivanushka: How much longer will we be stuck here, Rey? Will we really go to Budapest?

Reyhan lowers her head, stroking his hair softly.

Reyhan: Of course we will, little guy.

Rubuska: Budapest? Then, you're also ...

No words are needed. The scene says it all.

That scent, too familiar. The nightmare returns, always chasing her ...

Young Rubuska: Kolyo *sniffle* Kolyo, don't fall asleep, okay?

Gunfire still echoes. A village burns behind her. She clutches her brother, unable to look back at the ruins.

Kolyo: Buska, I can't feel my legs.

Young Rubuska: They're just a bit numb. It'll pass. You'll be fine. *sniff* I'll get us out of here.

Flames tear across the sky. A shell bursts overhead.

Young Rubuska: ...!

Kolyo: I think my legs are gone.

Kolyo: It-It hurts, Buska. It-It hurts so bad. I can't—

Young Rubuska: Oh. You'll be fine, Kolyo, alright? Your big sister's here. You're safe.

Young Rubuska: You'll feel better tomorrow. You'll be better.

Rubuska: ...

Ivanushka: Um, Ms. Vampire, what happened to your eyes? They've gone all red and watery, like a white rabbit's.

Rubuska: Huh? Oh, it's nothing. Happens every time I think of a happy memory. It's a vampire thing.

Rubuska: Hm?

She hears a faint sound by the door.

Step by step, quiet and patient.

Yakov: What is it?

Rubuska: Shh!

Rubuska: Someone's coming.

Rubuska signals the others to hush then presses her ear to the door.

Rubuska: Strange, I don't hear anything now. Was it just my imagination?

She lowers her head and sees a dim yellow glow seeping through the crack.

A shadow blocks the light, swaying with the train.

Rubuska: ...!

She turns in panic but meets the gaze of a helpless boy.

Ivanushka: Are the bad men coming for us again?

Ivanushka: I don't want to go with them.

His blue eyes look almost clear in the darkness.

Once before, in a world of ash and gunfire, another boy had looked at her the same way.

Rubuska: Kolyo ...

She draws a deep breath, making a solemn vow.

Rubuska: ... You're not going anywhere. I swear it on my honor as a vampire.

Rubuska: Just leave it to me. I'll get you all to Budapest, safe and sound.

Turning back, she faces the door.

Rubuska: Now, keep quiet.

They hold their breath.

Dozens of eyes weave a net around her, holding her spine steady, sealing every path of retreat.

Rubuska: Whoever you are ...

She spreads her arms, coat flaring wide, like a bat unfurling its wings in the night.

Rubuska: Sh-Show yourself! But don't think I'll let you touch a hair on their heads!

An effortless battle, yet the defeated refuses to yield.

???: Oh! That's quite enough!

???: I'm warning you—no fangs on the train, Rubuska.

Rubuska: Huh? What are you doing here?

Hearing her name called in that familiar voice, the girl slackens her grip.

Semmelweis: Funny, I had intended to ask you the same thing.

The yellow beam falls across weary, half-wild faces.

No one speaks. Her speed and skill intimidating the onlookers.

Semmelweis: No sign of Squad 77, and these people don't look like Manus, either. Could they be the "cargo" she was talking about?

Semmelweis: Are they civilians?

She pauses for a moment, then speaks again.

Semmelweis: Who brought you on board? The conductress? Think before you answer. I know more than you think.

Semmelweis: Why are you on this train?

...

Silence. Eyes filled with unease and suspicion fix on her. She knows only sincerity will break through the wall between them.

Semmelweis: Just listen please, I don't work for the border patrol, the army, nor the railway.

Semmelweis: If it's war, famine, or death you're running from, well, who could blame you? In times like these, anyone would do the same.

Semmelweis: My business here is with a vampire. If you don't have anything to do with one, then your purpose here is of no concern to me.

Stowaways: A vampire?

All at once, they turn to Rubuska.

Rubuska: Huh?

Rubuska: Could she mean me? Did you come here looking for me?

Semmelweis: I can see what you're all thinking, but it's not her. I thought perhaps it could be hiding in this carriage, but it appears I was wrong.

Rubuska: Oh ...

She nods, unsure whether in relief or regret.

Stowaway I: So the stories are true. Good thing we came prepared!

Stowaway II: That vampire ... It won't find us, will it?

Worried murmurs ripple through the carriage.

Semmelweis: Look, I'm willing to help you, but only if you give me some information about yourselves. After all, trust is a two-way street, right?

Yakov: I understand.

Yakov surveys the faces, sighing under his breath.

Yakov: We're refugees; we come from all over. Someone offered us a way out, and we took it. It's nothing more than that.

Yakov: We were told to wait near Belgrade station until a train stopped.

Yakov: They said someone would attach this carriage to the rear, and as long as we kept our heads down and stayed quiet, we could make it across the border.

Yakov: As for the conductress ... She didn't speak much. She said there'd be people on the other side, people who'd feed us, give us medicine, help us start a new life in Budapest.

Yakov: That's the whole of it.

Semmelweis: She's taking a huge risk for you. Smuggling you across the border could put her behind bars. She asked for a fair price, I assume?

The passengers shake their heads.

Reyhan: No, nothing. Only that we keep quiet and never speak a word about it to anyone who doesn't need to know.

Rubuska: Whoa ... I never would've figured her for something like that.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: But that Manus insignia ... How did she get it? And why did she give it to those soldiers?

Semmelweis: And I can't forget that the rest of my squad has vanished without a trace.

Semmelweis takes a glance outside—an unyielding screen of white snow.

She checks her watch.

Semmelweis: We'll be reaching the checkpoint any minute now.

Their time is short.

As if to confirm her calculation, the train begins to slow.

Yakov: We're stopping again. What's going on?

Yakov presses close to the door, peeking through the crack. His eyes suddenly brighten.

Yakov: You're right. It's the border checkpoint!

Yakov: Good news, folks—by tomorrow, we'll be out of the country!

Kreynero

CH31101-12

The train glides into a soft brake at the checkpoint.

The steel beast breathes out a final belch of dark smoke before it stops.

Border Checkpoint

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: The "Danube Dawn" ...

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Operated by Vienna-Pannonian Railways, 12 carriages.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Date of arrival: November 30th, 1912. Location: Nika Border Checkpoint.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Persons on board ... 250 ... 50 ...

The sound grows faint, looping over and over, as if trapped in a prison of numbers.

Corvus: Sir?

The conductress steps forward. The soldier's face, pale as moonlight, looks freshly recovered from a long illness.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Oh, er, just the usual checks. We'll have you on your way shortly.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Welcome to Nika checkpoint, Conductress.

Corvus: Pyrrhos, your chief officer—where is he? I need to see him.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Ma'am, he ...

His eyes drift before finally finding focus.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: He's expecting you. Said you'd know where to find him.

Pyrrhos: Iglika! Aima! What a joy to see you both again!

Pyrrhos: How's the trip treating you? All going well?

An officer strides in, smile warm and practiced.

Corvus: Just the usual.

Pyrrhos: Ah, well, there's nothing wrong with that. Aima, come.

Pyrrhos: Here. A refugee gave it to me.

Aima: Oh, Uncle Pyrrhos. Now I have all five of them. Thank you ever so much!

Pyrrhos: That's quite alright, my dear. Now, you be a good girl for Aunt Iglika, and maybe she'll sew you a dress for it, then you can line them all up, like one big family.

Aima strokes the wooden doll gently. Pyrrhos watches, his expression tired but kind.

Corvus: You look exhausted. Has there been trouble?

Pyrrhos: Do I? Perhaps I am a little worse for wear. Dealing with border patrol is always a pain. You know how it is.

He continues speaking, while his eyes flick subtly toward the stewardess.

Aima: Oh, yes. I just remembered I still have to clean the windows on the dining car. Thank you again, Uncle Pyrrhos.

Aima pockets the toy with understanding, then turns to leave.

The door shuts, and the officer's smile turns sour.

Pyrrhos: There are eyes on us, and not just some casual suspicion. I believe they may be professionals.

Pyrrhos: I just received word that two of my men were knocked out while on patrol—somehow without alerting anyone. Whoever did it was well trained.

Pyrrhos: All that is to say ...

Pyrrhos: Someone's sniffing us out, my friend.

Corvus: ...

Semmelweis: To rule out any threat, I need to verify every passenger on board, carriage by carriage.

Semmelweis: I am fully within my authority to stop this train at any time to conduct an investigation.

Pyrrhos: What's wrong?

Pyrrhos: I know that look. You know who's behind this, don't you?

Corvus: I'll handle it.

Pyrrhos: The St. Pavlov Foundation—you heard of them?

He wastes no time.

Corvus: ...

Pyrrhos: Oh, Iglika. *tut* You've met them already, haven't you? They're on your train as we speak.

Pyrrhos: How else could my men have been ambushed in such an isolated location? You're harboring a snake, my friend, whether you know it or not.

Corvus: She's not after the cargo. As for the assault, I will handle it.

Corvus: I won't allow anything to jeopardize the mission. This train must reach Budapest.

She dismisses his concern with a sharp wave.

Pyrrhos: *chuckle* Ah, makes me miss it.

Pyrrhos: I'll never forget the day you stood up for me. It's thanks to you that they even allowed me to stay with the guerrilla unit.

The officer narrows his eyes, mind slipping back to a faraway summer.

Pyrrhos: Things were simpler back then. All we cared about was the cause, about unity, and the Thracian Liberation Front.

Pyrrhos: Fighting for a world where, regardless of race or bloodline, we'd all live as one great family.

Pyrrhos: We crossed forests, trudged through the snow over the mountains, and turned the enemy's supply lines to dust, heh. We scared those cavalrymen half to death.

Pyrrhos: And when night fell, we'd gather around the fire, break bread, clean our sights, and sing those songs of war and liberation, like brothers and sisters. You remember, don't you, Iglika?

Corvus: It was a good life.

Pyrrhos: What a shame that not everyone shared our vision. Betrayal, bloodshed, comrades parting ways ... We went through all of it together.

Pyrrhos: In the end, even we chose to walk away. And now, after all these years ...

Pyrrhos: I have a second chance to fight for what we believe in—the "Danube Dawn."

His voice softens as he leans against the window.

As he turns, the scar at his temple shows raw and red, like burnt vines.

Pyrrhos: I've always felt we were kindred minds, you and I.

Pyrrhos: I trusted you then, and I trust you now. I won't take any action against the Foundation—

He pauses.

Pyrrhos: On two conditions.

Pyrrhos: First, the train mustn't leave until morning.

Pyrrhos: We need it here long enough to go through some procedures and put together a justifiable account of the assault.

Corvus: "Procedures"? You mean ...

Pyrrhos: I'm getting there. Second—

Pyrrhos: I need to conduct a full search of the train.

Same old talk. Stops, papers, inspections ... it never ends.

Corvus: The train's already been searched. You'd only raise more concern with the passengers.

Corvus: I can provide you the passenger list if you must check.

Pyrrhos shakes his head.

Pyrrhos: Believe me, my people don't enjoy this any more than yours do. But ... *tut* word has gotten out. It's only a matter of time until people start asking questions about the attack.

Pyrrhos: Besides, better that I do it, rather than getting the government or the company involved. We wouldn't want their prying eyes looking any closer, now would we?

Corvus: ...

His point is made. The conductress carefully chooses her next words.

Corvus: One of my crew members will be with you at all times. And tell your men to stay clear of the "cargo."

Corvus: As for the time we're losing, I need compensation: food, medicine, and priority clearance when we reach Budapest.

Corvus: The paperwork there is cumbersome, and each minute the train is stopped risks our "cargo" being exposed.

Corvus: It's give and take. Do we have a deal?

Pyrrhos: ...

His expression blanks, then yields a faint resignation.

Pyrrhos: Iglika, Iglika ... *tut* I knew you wouldn't make this easy. You never do.

Corvus: This is a fair negotiation, Pyrrhos, for both of us.

Corvus: We both have responsibilities to attend to, yes?

Seating Carriage

The door creaks open. The conductress leads, her steps firm, face lightened by unusual ease.

Pyrrhos follows, neither angry nor content.

Aima: *yawn* Finally. Is everything alright? That was a long talk.

Pyrrhos: Of course, sweetheart. I got a little carried away talking about the good old days, and I should know better than to challenge your boss at the bargaining table.

He mutters complaints, then bends low, voice dropping.

Pyrrhos: Listen, I'm sorry we haven't had a chance to talk. There's a lot on my plate right now.

Pyrrhos: But when I'm done, I have another "gift" for you.

Aima: Another? But Uncle Pyrrhos, my closet is already bursting.

Pyrrhos: Shhh, this one's a secret. You'll see soon enough.

With a wink and a lazy stretch, he trails after the conductress, out of sight.

Echoes of the Past

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...

Alright, moment of silence over.

Oh, I'm not a believer—not an atheist either. But I do respect her sacrifice.

Even if it was stupid and meaningless.

But, as I said before, there's no greater proof of loyalty than to follow a fool.

At least she died for a cause—her family legacy, her spirit of exploration, even that children's fairytale.

She was stupid, but she was faithful.

Choices

1. It happened so fast.

2. You're cold-blooded.

Branch 1

Were you expecting a warning first? I thought you'd know better after what you've been through.

Sorry, but you won't hear any praise from me for a sentimental commander.

If I were your superior, I'd tell you to rip out your own heart and let the others see what sentiment leads to.

Branch 2

Oh, come on. You and I both know this isn't the end for her.

For someone as devoted as her, death is nothing more than the achievement of eternal life.

She's not like those blind followers who cut off their tongues. In fact, at this very moment, I fear she's being confronted with her own beliefs.

Join her now, while the gate is still open.

Or she'll leave you behind for good.

Shared continuation

Excerpt from the New York Times

Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
The victims entered the forest at dusk. Identities of 6 of them have been confirmed: the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers Tomson Joyce, Shelley Gerald, Kelly Keith, and the project manager Russell James. The others' are still being verified.

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Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

The Non-Returnees

CH31101-13

Outside the carriage come heavy footsteps, followed by a wave of restless complaints.

The Extra Carriage

Yakov: You hear that? Boots. Sounds like soldiers.

Reyhan: Could it be Pyrrhos again?

Semmelweis: Pyrrhos?

Yakov: An army officer. He's working with the conductress to get us out of here.

A new name, a new problem.

Semmelweis frowns.

Semmelweis: Come on, Rubuska. Time to go.

Rubuska: Huh? Oh, right! I'm supposed to be in Aima's cabin. I better not be seen here.

Ivanushka: W-Wait! Ms. Rubuska!

Just about to leave, she turns back to face the boy.

Ivanushka: Th-Thank you for protecting us. I-I hope I can be brave like you when I grow up.

Ivanushka: You're a good vampire!

She can't help but smile as she leans down to pat his head.

Rubuska: And you're a good boy, Ivanushka.

Rubuska: Now listen, this good vampire has to go up front for a bit. But I'll be back soon with news from the other carriages.

Rubuska: No one will hurt you, you got that? Not while I'm around. Here, pinky promise.

She reaches out her right hand to Ivanushka, hooking her pinky.

So Ivanushka lifts his good hand, pinky finger locking with hers.

Their promise is sealed.

Ivanushka: I'll be waiting for you. You promised, so come back soon, Rubuska.

Rubuska: Don't worry, I will. Look, I'll take this.

She picks up the wooden stake at her feet and gives it a little shake.

Rubuska: As a token of our promise. So you better hold the fort for me until I bring it back, alright?

Seating Carriage

Corvus: Ladies and gentlemen, please bear with us while we conduct a routine check.

Annabelle: A-Are you going to take us too? Like you did with Rubuska?

Little William: You give her back right now! Or I'll ... I'll lie down right here! I-I'll be an unmovable object!

The boy flings himself to the ground, clenching his pudgy fists like a martyr ready to face his fate.

It's his final card to play, a tactic that has worked on the adults before, and one that he's counting on to work now.

Corvus: If you are set on being "unmovable," I'd be happy to stitch you into the carpet.

Little William: ...

He swallows hard.

Little William: I-I'm not moving! Not until Rubuska's back!

Verity: Another search? Again?

Verity: I suppose you can never be too sure whether someone's transformed into a beast over lunchtime.

Aima: We're ever so sorry for the inconvenience, but this is for your safety; we just have to check whether ...

Sonya: Oh, I have something to "check" too, young lady. Namely, whether anyone on this crew actually has a brain knocking around in their heads!

Sonya: You say this is for our safety, but all you've done is stir up chaos. You ought to be ashamed!

The carriage is in chaos.

People leave their seats, crowding and shouting. The tension seems about to erupt into fresh turmoil.

Pyrrhos: That's quite enough commotion, everyone.

The officer slides his pistol back into his belt as if it were nothing more than a pen—just a tool.

In the uneasy silence, another sound breaks through.

Hrrrk ... Urrrgh ... Rkkk ...

A slow, irregular churning, like the rumbling stomach of some terrible creature.

The noise dips, then rises again into a catlike whimper.

wail

All eyes turn toward the pale-faced gentleman in the corner.

Arbuthnot: I ... W-What're you all starin' for?

Arbuthnot: That weren't me.

Footsteps echo.

Semmelweis strides through the gathered people at a quick pace, with Rubuska trailing close behind.

Corvus: What are you two doing here?

Semmelweis: Please, allow me through. There's something wrong.

She moves as she speaks, grabbing Arbuthnot's wrist and yanking it away.

Arbuthnot: Watch it! I told you, it weren't me.

She shoves him aside and looks at the slumped stranger hiding behind him.

Semmelweis: Who are you? I didn't see you during the registration.

Semmelweis: Can you speak, sir?

Unwell Passenger: ...

The passenger can hardly lift his face to meet hers.

His face is chalk-white. Red streaks score outward from his pupils.

Then he opens his mouth, revealing a thick, black sea of blood swirling inside.

Unwell Passenger: Chk ... Chklga—

Passengers: AAAAHHHH!

Unwell Passenger: H-Help ...

He collapses, choking on the blood, gurgling as he swallows it back down.

The investigator kneels and pries open his eyelids.

Semmelweis: An Infected?

Semmelweis: But this looks nothing like the usual symptoms. A mutation, perhaps?

Corvus: ...!

Passenger III: Hold on! Hold on! Would anyone care to explain this? What's an Infected? Infected by what?

Verity: A pinch of cold, a dash of salmonella, and a spoonful of tuberculosis—what do you think?

Verity: He's been bitten by a vampire.

Passenger III: Va-Vampire?!

Overwhelmed with shock, the passenger faints.

Passenger I: My goodness. A vampire? On this train? I figured those were just old stories.

Pyrrhos: Oh, dear. Looks like we've got an unwelcome guest aboard. Iglika, did that strange girl do this?

He looks toward Rubuska.

Pyrrhos: I overheard the children talking about some shadowless "vampire boss."

Dorothy: Oh my. I thought it was just a silly game!

Everyone turns to Rubuska in a convicting silence. Without her hat, there is no hiding those ruby eyes.

Their fears find a cause.

Passenger IV: I knew there was something wrong with her the moment she came on board. All that shouting and running about.

Passenger II: And look, she's awfully pale, too.

Rubuska: No. No, it wasn't me.

Pyrrhos: This isn't a courtroom; there's no use pleading your case. You're going to have to leave the train.

Pyrrhos: After all, we can't have a vampire wandering free on a train full of ordinary people now, can we?

Pyrrhos: You'll have to find your next bite elsewhere, kid.

Pyrrhos signals to his men.

Pyrrhos: Take her away.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Yes, sir.

Heavy boots stomp closer as two soldiers seize Rubuska by the arms.

Rubuska: Don't touch me, ah! Let me go! You've got it all wrong!

Little William: She said: Don't touch her!

In the next instant, several children rush from the crowd, tugging at the soldiers and shouting.

Annabelle: Please, sir, please listen! Maybe it's a mistake!

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Hey, back off! Whose kids are these? They're interfering with a military operation!

One soldier raises his rifle in irritation.

Dorothy: They're with me! For crying out loud, you two, come back here!

Rubuska: Annabelle! This is grown-up stuff, okay? You've got to stay out of it!

The children don't budge. Annabelle clutches a coat hem, looking up at Rubuska in panic.

In all the chaos, hers is the only face sharp and clear.

Annabelle: Run, boss!

...

...

Mother: Run, Buska.

The air reeks of gunpowder.

No one is hurt, but a jagged dent scars the ceiling.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Last warning! Where are your parents?

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Argh!

In the chaos, a small figure breaks free and hurls herself at the soldier.

Annabelle: No! Boss—Rubuska!

Rubuska locks onto his arm, her fangs sinking deep into his skin, sucking as if to drain every drop from him.

Rubuska: *muffled* Put it down!

Before the End

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Heavy rain will eventually cause a flood. It's an obvious deduction.

This is my final report. The era of mankind and birds is over, and the era of fish has begun.

But the fish will have to wait a little longer. Because you've delayed the doomsday by about an hour.

Every living person now owes you an hour of their lives. How big do you think your medal should be?

Choices

1. There must be a way.

2. Just shut up.

Branch 1

Certainly. Even if the umbrellas don't work, you still have an ark.

Just as long as you only take the "qualified animals" with you, like in old times ...

You should be able to continue to fight.

Branch 2

Please, let me finish my final report, even if you don't want to hear it.

Thanks to gravity, those on higher ground live longer in a flood.

Which gives you plenty of time to cuddle up with your greyhound and watch the end of the world together.

Or ... you could do what a soldier would and follow your orders till the very last moment.

"Find that writer."

You know how important this mission is.

Shared continuation

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Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

The Conqueror Worm

CH31101-14

But see, amid the mimic rout,

A crawling shape intrude!

A blood-red thing that writhes from out

The scenic solitude!

It writhes!—it writhes!—with mortal pangs.

— Edgar Allan Poe, The Conqueror Worm

Seating Carriage

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Tch. Damn vampire!

The soldier hurls the girl aside, his hand marked with two clear bite wounds.

Rubuska: Hahaha ...

She bares her teeth, fangs dripping red.

Rubuska: Look who's going to be a "damn vampire" now? Hah! Guess I'll have a little company in that cell!

Arbuthnot: Bloody hell!

Sonya: Oh, that's just wonderful! This train will be infested with vampires before long.

The gathered people form a ring around the soldier and the girl. The children are pulled close by Dorothy.

Rubuska: ...

Heat surges through her body, her heart pounding faster and faster.

She locks on him. Yes, any second now, he will pale and collapse.

His veins will branch like spring twigs, crawling into his eyes and mouth, then spray jets of blood like a fountain.

And ...

Nothing happens.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Hahaha! I didn't feel a thing. You little brat.

The soldier raises his hand to strike her.

But his wrist is seized. A cold voice cuts in.

Corvus: Enough. Pyrrhos, this was not a part of our deal. Discipline your men, or I will.

Corvus lets go, annoyance flickering across her face.

Pyrrhos: Easy now. This fellow's just a little on edge. I'll see to it that he learns his lesson, I assure you.

Pyrrhos: But for now, we seem to have a far more intriguing problem.

He steps forward unhurried, stopping before Rubuska, sneering down at her.

Rubuska: *cough* Why hasn't he—

Rubuska: He should've turned by now. I-I bit him—tasted his blood.

Pyrrhos: How adorable. Still living in your fairytale world, are we, little lady?

He crouches, studying her crimson eyes.

Pyrrhos: Tell me—why would you pretend to be a vampire?

Rubuska: ...!

Her lips tremble. Suddenly she feels cold.

Rubuska: I-I'm not pretending. I-I am.

Pyrrhos: *tut* Come now. Those little tricks—the red eyes, no shadow? Very clever. Quite the flair for theatrics, in fact.

Pyrrhos: But I've come face-to-face with real monsters, little lady, and you're not one of them. You may be human or arcanist.

Pyrrhos: But a vampire? *scoff* Not a chance.

Rubuska: ...

Rubuska: What? I-I don't understand what you're saying.

Rubuska tries to shrink away, but her shadow, beneath her quaking feet, betrays her.

Little William: Look! Her shadow—it's moving!

Rubuska: ...!

Rubuska: This ... I ...

The shadow grows and warps, then retreats again into a modest, ordinary shape.

She looks at those around her, finding suspicion, distance, pity ...

Emotions that weave into a suffocating trap.

Annabelle: Boss ...

Rubuska: I—No, I'm telling the truth!

The words tumble out quick and desperate.

Rubuska: I am the youngest descendant of Dracula himself. Daughter of Arnold VI, the greatest night-ruler of our time!

Rubuska: Together, we defeated Conrad the Wicked and his monster of a son, and then ...

Rubuska: And then the war came! It tore apart our home, and only I survived! Me! Rubuska the vampire!

Rubuska: The Shadowless, the Unbleeding, the Unwoundable!

Her eyes shine with madness, cheeks flushed rose-red by fevered daydreams.

Rubuska: I crawled over mountains of corpses, waded through rivers of blood, ran between fire and screaming shells.

Rubuska: Everything and everyone's gone, except me! I lived!

Rubuska: I carry the strength of my father, mother, sisters, and brothers.

Rubuska: Their blood runs through my veins!

She falters, panting, her gaze full of near-hopeless yearning.

Rubuska: I'm *pant* I'm the powerful, deathless vampire Rubus—

thump

Her legs give way, body crumpling like her bones are gone.

The officer lowers his rifle butt without expression, hauls her up by the arm, and drags her aside.

Pyrrhos: Unbelievable. She sure knows how to give a speech.

Pyrrhos: Bring her to the warehouse at the station. Keep her in a separate room.

The unconscious "vampire" is thrown over a soldier's shoulder and carried off.

Corvus: This is too far, Pyrrhos. She is not a vampire.

Pyrrhos: No, but she pretended to be one, didn't she? And she obstructed my men's duties. Besides ...

He looks over the passengers who fainted on the floor, his voice rising.

Pyrrhos: With an Infected onboard, we can't take any chances. Until we're sure there aren't more of them, the train will have to be kept under quarantine.

Corvus: This is my train. We will handle this my way.

Corvus: We must reach Budapest on schedule. We don't have time for this.

Pyrrhos: So, you'll handle it, will you? After letting a vampire slip right under your nose and still having no clue where it is?

Pyrrhos shrugs toward the whispering passengers, glancing toward the conductress with doubt.

Sonya: This is utterly unacceptable. To have all these delays and let a vampire on board of all things?

Passenger II: Maybe it'd be better if the army just took over. At least they seem to know what they're doing.

Corvus: ...

Pyrrhos: Need I say more?

He motions to his waiting troops.

Soldiers march in, quickly filling the carriage.

Pyrrhos: Listen up, everyone! My men will escort you to a safe location shortly. Just stay seated for now and remain calm. So long as you cooperate, I promise everything will be fine.

Corvus: So this is your plan? To turn my passengers against me and seize control of the train?

Corvus: Why? What's in it for you?

Pyrrhos: *tut* Come now, Iglika. I'm only doing my duty. You should know that after all these years.

As more soldiers press in, he murmurs instructions and flips through the passenger list.

Pyrrhos: Let's see. Nicola, Alexander, Jovan—you three come with me.

Pyrrhos: As for the rest of you ... Well, I suggest you stay put. Any risky or dangerous behavior will be dealt with accordingly.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis keeps her eyes trained on the armed men but maintains a low profile.

Semmelweis: Something's not right. If that man truly is Infected, his symptoms developed much quicker than any case I've ever heard of.

She opens her palm, staring at the dull badge etched with the mark of Manus Vindictae.

Semmelweis: But he also made a fair point. With all these civilians in a confined space, if another Infected shows up, it'll be a massacre.

Semmelweis: Is this what you wanted, Manus Vindictae?

Lark Cake

CH31101-15

Maggots—so many of them—wriggling, squirming, biting.

I know they've rotted away, that their bodies have melted into the mud. I know that.

Still, I remember a face—her face.

Pressed into the ground, red with blood, black with mud and rainwater, but still, I saw the warm brown of her eyes.

They looked at me, they wept, until her breathing stopped, and the tears turned dry.

"The Face": Go.

"The Face": Run for your life.

That's all she said, like they were the only words she could remember.

Young Rubuska: No. I don't want to.

Young Rubuska: I don't want to leave you, Мама.

"The Face": Go ... Run ...

"The Face": You must go.

Run, Buska!

RUN!

Those words never left me.

I hear them whenever the light gets low, just as I'm about to fall asleep, or as I run through the woods with everything I have. It's like a second shadow, one that covers me entirely.

Young Rubuska: Мама ... No ...

I cried. I bawled. What else could I do?

Run. That's what.

As far as I could. As fast as I could.

And I buried the screams. Buried the gunshots. Buried her face deep in my memory.

And never looked back.

Cemetery at Dusk

Young Rubuska: There you go, Dad.

Young Rubuska: Now, Kolyo!

Young Rubuska: You've grown a lot, haven't you?

Young Rubuska: Okay. *pant*

Young Rubuska: And last ...

Young Rubuska: It's your turn, Мама.

Young Rubuska: ...

The guns and the strangers who wielded them have gone for now, leaving behind fields caked with blood and bodies lost to eternal slumber.

When all settles, the village is nothing but a scorched ruin.

The girl buries her family together in a nameless pit.

Father, mother, and little Kolyo lie neatly arranged, like porcelain dolls on a bed of dirt and leaves.

Young Rubuska: Why are you all sleeping? It's still light out.

Young Rubuska: I don't want to be the only one awake. Let's all fall asleep together, alright?

She lies down with them, curling close to her mother, pulling a stiffened arm around her chest.

Young Rubuska: This is nice, like when I was little, and you used to hold me, Мама. When we wake up, will you comb my hair?

Cold fingers tangle in her hair, yet in her mind it feels like comfort.

Young Rubuska: Мама, tell me a story, would you? Please? I know you've told the vampire story a hundred times, but just once more, please.

Young Rubuska: "In the light of the blood moon, they rise and stride under the veil of night."

Young Rubuska: "Freely, they live, without fear of death."

Young Rubuska: "For through blood they live forevermore."

Her breath is shallow. Consciousness slips away with whispered stories as her eyes close, and she falls into slumber.

Because blood is life.

Young Rubuska: Because blood is life!

Young Rubuska: That's right! As long as they drink blood, vampires can rise from their graves and live forever!

The girl bolts upright, pallid face glowing with a strange light.

She bites her finger and smears the flowing blood over her mother's lips.

For a moment she believes in miracles.

The blood beads on cold lips, glowing like red agate, lighting up death's grim mask.

Young Rubuska: ...!

The girl smiles with delight.

Young Rubuska: Yes, good, Мама!

Young Rubuska: A little for Dad, too, and for Kolyo.

Young Rubuska: All set!

She smears thick, almost comical streaks of blood across her family's lips.

Young Rubuska: Yeah, we're just like the story!

Young Rubuska: Dad, Мама, Kolyo, and Rubuska—a vampire family!

Young Rubuska: That's why Мама likes to wear lipstick. It's just like blood.

Young Rubuska: Here, have a little more, Мама.

She caresses their faces tenderly.

Young Rubuska: Am I a clever girl? I figured it out. Now, we'll all wake up soon, right?

Young Rubuska: I know it might take a while, but I'll wait.

Young Rubuska: Don't worry. I'll be right here, watching over you.

A breeze lifts. A bird's cry drifts in from afar.

The girl looks toward the scarlet-red sunset, sniffs, and raises her tiny fist to the sky.

Young Rubuska: Don't even try to touch my family, you hear me?!

Young Rubuska: I'm Rubuska the vampire, descendant of Dracula himself!

Young Rubuska: I'll rise in the light of the blood moon and stride under the veil of night!

Young Rubuska: I'll live freely, without fear of death!

Young Rubuska: I'll watch over my blood forever and ever—

Young Rubuska: —forevermore!

Her vow is sharp and unyielding, the fiery voice of a young but powerful child of an ancient and noble vampiric bloodline.

???: Liar.

Young Rubuska: Huh? Who's there?

She looks down again, and the illusion breaks. Cold blood dries on rotting faces. Their mouths bent into grotesque smiles.

Young Rubuska: Who are you?

Young Rubuska: Kolyo! What happened to your clothes? Мама's going to be mad at you!

Their eyes are milky and puckered dry, bodies cold and sagging, gray faces gaunt—blood-soaked and tattered clothes the last vestiges of their identities.

Young Rubuska: Мама, Мама, Мама, wake up. Please, please hold me.

Young Rubuska: No! NO!

Young Rubuska: Мама! Dad!

She screams, ripping cloth, scrubbing furiously at their faces, but the flesh gives way like ripened cheese.

Young Rubuska: No! You're not dead. We're vampires! We can't die!

Her rough wiping tugs at their mouths, baring smiles soaked in blood.

???: Hahahaha ...

Laughter swells, spilling from red lips, from the sky, from the corpses, howling, echoing, like a thousand bells ringing at once.

???: Lies! All of it.

???: Red eyes, fangs, the resurrection of our family—all lies!

Young Rubuska: No ...

Terrified, she runs toward the distant red sun.

No matter how far she goes, the laughter seems to chase her.

???: Off you run! Hahaha.

Go, run, Rubuska!

Run!

Rubuska: ...!

Rubuska jolts awake from a deep sleep.

Rubuska: It's not a lie.

Rubuska: ...

Her heart slows. Her eyes adjust to the dark.

The stench beside her is revolting and bitterly familiar—death, mixed with fuel and smoke.

She turns her gaze and meets another face, swollen and bluish.

Rubuska: ...

A corpse, stiff and cold. Black veins coil beneath its pale skin like twisted branches of a dead tree.

Her eyes follow the body upward until they freeze on a face she knows—one she has seen before, back at the snowbound station.

Passenger I: No, no, not precisely, but many like it. Vampires, werewolves, wild beasts, and monsters.

Passenger I: It's always the same story about the powerful consuming the common folk. Heh, storytellers have always been good at making their points one way or another.

Rubuska: It's that old man from the train station.

The irony of his warnings is a bitter mix of comedy and tragedy.

???: You are awake.

A shadow in the corner stirs, taking the shape of a looming man.

Pyrrhos: Thirsty?

Rubuska: You-you're that officer. What is all of this? Did you ... Did you kill these people?

Pyrrhos ignores the questions.

The rag drags across the floor with a heavy scrape, tossed casually to Rubuska's feet.

Pyrrhos: I'm afraid I haven't been a very good host, and alas, our water supply has run dry. Blood, however? Well, we've got plenty of that.

Pyrrhos extends his hand, long blackened nails stroking the corpse's wrist with a vile tenderness.

Pyrrhos: Drink up, Little Miss "Vampire."

Blood runs down Rubuska's hair, lashes, eyes, nose, finally her mouth.

Rubuska: *cough* Blrrrghh!

Her nose fills with the stench of blood. She collapses halfway to the floor, retching violently.

Stew, frozen berries, honey bread, lark cake ...

Everything she's eaten pours out with each spasm, mingling with the foul blood and shredded organs on the ground.

Pyrrhos: Not so demure at the table, are we? *tut* How embarrassing. I knew you weren't one of us.

Rubuska: *pant* You ...

She lifts her pale face and meets the man's horrid gaze.

His eyes are pure crimson, flawless, like a sea of blood flowing under moonlight.

An undeniable bloodline. An undeniable identity.

Rubuska: You're a vampire, too?

Pyrrhos: Through and through. But you? It seems not to be so.

Pyrrhos: Still lost in your dreamland, little imposter?

Rubuska: Don't call me that.

Rubuska: My family—my blood—they'll rise from the grave soon, you'll see! We'll be together again.

She chokes and swallows the blood until her face and body are smeared with scarlet.

A lie—that day will never come.

Rubuska: ...

Pyrrhos: Hahahaha ...

The man cackles.

Pyrrhos: Aren't you a sorry little thing? It almost stirs something in this useless old heart.

Pyrrhos: In fact, I've almost come to like you. Tell you what, I could make your wish come true.

Rubuska: My wish?

His blood-red eyes gleam with unfathomable danger.

Pyrrhos: You heard me. I can help you ...

Pyrrhos: Become a real vampire.

Meaningless Questions

小径

Another near-drowning. How nostalgic.

Take it easy. You can't move yet. Just stay right there and listen to the report.

Choices

1. Wasn't the last one the "final" report?

2. My cheek feels warm.

Branch 1

Urgh ...

Okay. You win.

You did it, noble savior. You turned the tide and saved the world at the last moment.

And I didn't see it coming. There. Are you satisfied? Can we get to the report now?

Branch 2

It's your loyal greyhound licking your wounds. She's doing whatever she can to wake you up—another metaphor, of course. I'm sure I don't need to explain it.

Just another reason not to wake up yet. The salt water will get in your eyes ...

And that'll just be embarrassing for everyone. So you just keep lying there and listen to me.

You almost drowned again, but not because you're a bad swimmer.

No, it's because you'd rather die than let that spinning wheel go.

But a spinning wheel is a spinning wheel, no matter how precious the thread it spins is—and you already have one.

What's the use in having two? You're the only spinner, after all.

And even if you tear it apart, its broken components can't be used to fix yours. Just because two things look alike doesn't mean they're interchangeable.

This is a universal truth. Not just for spinning wheels, but for animals, fathers and sons—mothers and daughters.

Choices

1. I need to wake up.

2. I'm done talking. Leave me alone.

Branch 2.1

Just wait a moment longer. The greyhound's looking for your hat.

This is the only thing she can think to do besides first aid measures.

It's cute, isn't it? Seeing her so naive and superstitious. We should play along for a little longer.

Branch 2.2

Sure, you deserve a moment of quiet, savior.

Forget about the mess out there. Take a break.

Don't rest for too long, though. The greyhound's on her way back with your hat.

If you're not awake by the time she arrives, there's no telling what she'll do.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Excerpt from the New York Times

Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
The victims entered the forest at dusk. Identities of 6 of them have been confirmed: the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers Tomson Joyce, Shelley Gerald, Kelly Keith, and the project manager Russell James. The others' are still being verified.

The Weyerhaeuser used to be a leader in the wood industry, yet it went bankrupt not long ago due to the wood supply crisis these years. After donating the formula of the Resurrection Potion (basic version) to the Maria Sanatorium in New York, the Sacred Heart Sanatorium in Ohio, and the Presbyterian Church Health Center on certain conditions, the Weyerhaeusers sold all of their forestry lands.
On the night of the fire, the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers, and the workers went into the forest to start the disafforestation project before they died. The police has found traces of arcanist's activities and a small amount of gasoline at the scene, which shows the case is an arson attack. More investigations are needed to identify the suspect.

Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

Winter Fright Night

CH31101-16

Conductress's Cabin

Little William: No. I'm not going with you! NEVER!

Little William clings to the seat rail, screaming loud enough to pierce steel.

After the quarantine order, passengers are scattered, some herded into the conductress's cabin.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Let go.

Soldiers pry open the boy's stubborn fingers one by one.

Semmelweis: Officers, with all due respect, you've taken a dozen passengers already.

Semmelweis: May I ask where you're taking them?

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Shh!

A rifle raises, muzzle aimed at the boot now wedged in the doorframe.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Step back, ma'am.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Nobody leaves the carriage until quarantine is over.

Semmelweis: ...

She says nothing but pulls her foot back.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Thank you.

Border Checkpoint Soldier I: Just work with us, please, and soon this'll all be over.

The soldier slings the boy under his arm and marches off.

Little William: Annabelle! No!

The heavy lock clicks shut, leaving only anxious passengers and stone-faced soldiers.

Passenger II: No food, no water, and no idea how long they'll keep us. This isn't separation. It's imprisonment!

Passenger III: Worse than that! At least prisoners know their sentence!

Annabelle: They took William and Ms. Dorothy, and Rubuska hasn't come back, either.

Sensing the soldier's warning glare, the girl clutches her doll tight.

Semmelweis: ...

She presses her communicator and is met with static.

Her words and any vital intelligence she could share are stranded with her.

Semmelweis: Something's jamming my signal. And the teleport disk isn't working either. Heh, someone came prepared.

Semmelweis approaches the door and peers through the window into the next car.

Semmelweis: ...

The scene is carnage.

The once opulent carriage is a spectacle of disaster, its walls painted with blood.

Semmelweis: What on earth ...?

???: Aaahahah!

A low, drawn-out wail comes from the corner.

Semmelweis: Hm? Seems a little early for that soldier to be back.

Border Checkpoint Soldier II: What the—Everything alright?

Border Checkpoint Soldier II: Ah. Idiot. Better go check on him.

The soldier stiffens, lifts his rifle, and hurries away.

Semmelweis: He's gone. Conductress, I think it's time you and I had a heart-to-heart.

She steps up to the conductress, blunt and direct.

Semmelweis: This is all wrong.

Semmelweis: No food, no water, no radio signal. I don't believe they're doing anything to protect the passengers from infection. This isn't a quarantine; this is a cover-up.

Corvus: What are you suggesting?

The investigator reveals the badge in her hand.

Semmelweis: This insignia. I believe you have one just like it.

Corvus: That's what you were sniffing around for.

Semmelweis: It belongs to an organization I've been tracking—Manus Vindictae.

Corvus: Manus Vindictae?

Semmelweis: At first, I thought you were one of them. Yet here you are, locked up like the rest of us. Perhaps Pyrrhos doesn't trust you all that much.

Corvus's look of confusion—certainly genuine—serves to confirm her suspicion.

Semmelweis: The Manus are a group of extremist arcanists that take pleasure in chaos and despair. Heartless bastards, every last one of them.

Corvus: Never heard of them. The badge is Pyrrhos's, some kind of identifier for his men.

Semmelweis: When I took this mission, our intelligence suggested that the vampire I'm after may be associated with Manus Vindictae. If Pyrrhos is working with them, he could be working with the vampire aboard.

Semmelweis: It's possible, indeed, that he could be the vampire himself.

Corvus: ...

Corvus: Pyrrhos is a vampire.

No more evasions and equivocal answers, the conductress calmly reveals the truth.

Corvus: We were comrades-in-arms once. One of the most capable fighters we had—clever, composed, he always made the right decisions when it counted.

Corvus: I would never have thought he'd be involved with such an organization.

Semmelweis: I'm afraid it's almost certain that he's the vampire Manus Vindictae had sent to this train.

At last, a lead. Semmelweis breathes a long, drawn-out breath, letting the weight fall off her shoulders.

Semmelweis: Now that things are out in the open, do you have any idea what happened to my squad?

The reply comes with a resigned shake of her head.

Corvus: No. I haven't seen any of them.

Corvus: I'd know. As I've said before, this isn't the first time we've had the Foundation aboard. Last time there was a confrontation between them and some other arcanists.

Semmelweis: Hah. Sometimes, I think causing trouble might be our primary mission.

Semmelweis: But let's return to our vampire. I'm still not certain what Manus Vindictae is up to, but ...

Corvus: That vampire infection couldn't have been a coincidence. Someone meant for it to happen.

The conductress sneers, her fingers tracing the silver engraving on her pistol.

Corvus: I've known Pyrrhos a long time. But lately he's been strange. I usually wouldn't attempt to interfere with his business.

Corvus: But these are my passengers—my train.

Semmelweis: Glad to see we're finally on the same page. So, Conductress, can you get us out of here?

Corvus: Haste makes waste, Investigator. There's a loose thread I'm waiting for, then we can pull all of this together.

Semmelweis: We're long past the point for patience, if you ask me.

Annabelle: Ah!

A bloody hand slaps the window, smearing crimson streaks down the glass.

???: Oh ...

Semmelweis: Another Infected!

Semmelweis: What was that about "haste makes waste," Conductress?

Corvus: ...

Infected Passenger: Through. Let me through.

Thud. Thud.

The man mumbles flatly, headbutting the glass again and again until blood pours from his brow.

Infected Passenger: Let me through.

Annabelle: Ah!

Annabelle: He's ... He's breaking in.

Infected Passenger: Let me through, let me through, let me through, let me through.

Semmelweis: Conductress, there must be something muting arcane skills on this train.

Corvus: Arcane skills aren't everything.

She pulls the passengers behind her, draws her sidearm, and takes aim.

Infected Passenger: Uggh!

Before the shot fires, the infected passenger is yanked away by an unseen force.

Another splash of blood smears across the window.

Semmelweis: What was that? Another Infected?

The sound dies. Then comes a faint rustling outside the door.

A familiar face rises into view beyond the glass.

Aima: No. It's just me.

Semmelweis: Is she what you were waiting for, Conductress?

Corvus: Exactly. Aima, you drew that soldier away, yes?

Aima: Mm-hm. I waited for just the right moment.

Corvus: Well done. What's our situation?

Aima: There are Infected everywhere—the cabins, the hallways—all through the train. They seem to be running out from the station warehouse.

The stewardess goes pale, recounting everything she saw outside.

Aima: There's blood everywhere, too, on the walls, on the floor ... I tried my best not to look at it.

Semmelweis: Was it you who killed that Infected just now?

Aima: Well ...

She tugs shyly at her eyepatch.

Corvus: I ensure all crew on the "Danube Dawn" are trained in self-defense. It's hardly surprising.

Corvus: Go ahead, Aima.

Aima: Oh, yes.

She lowers her head, clenched fist trembling.

Aima: I saw those soldiers in their carriages. I thought they'd be caring for the passengers or removing the Infected, but ...

Aima: They did nothing, as if it were of no concern to them whatsoever.

Aima: They took the passengers, one by one, to some kind of detention room for inspection, then sent them to the warehouse. But then they started coming back out, like that.

She wipes a smear of blood from her cheek, then slips her finger briefly into her mouth.

Aima: Uncle Pyrrhos ... I don't know what's happened to him, but we have to find him.

Corvus: I see. How many soldiers remain aboard the train?

Aima: Not many. A few were sent to guard the detention room. I-I think we can handle the ones that are left!

The meek girl pumps her fist in an uncommon gesture of confidence.

Corvus: Good. Everything is in place; let's move.

Aima: Wait, shh. I hear footsteps.

Aima: They saw me just then. I can't be seen here again.

Aima's eye darts around before she ducks behind the curtains.

Then, the door is opened forcefully.

Border Checkpoint Soldier II: Damn it. This is getting out of hand.

Soldiers, having dealt with the "unexpected occurrence," rush in, weapons raised at the frightened passengers.

Border Checkpoint Soldier II: Where were we? On to the next passenger.

The muzzle drifts left and right, finally settling on Annabelle.

Border Checkpoint Soldier II: You. Little girl. It's your turn.

Annabelle: Me? I don't want to go!

Border Checkpoint Soldier II: Come now, be quiet.

The muzzle is locked in place.

Corvus: You heard her.

Corvus: She said: No.

In the scuffle, two shots ring out, each slamming into the metal ceiling.

The soldier tries to wrench back his rifle, but Corvus's grip is unyielding.

Border Checkpoint Soldier II: You! Let go!

Corvus: She's not going.

Border Checkpoint Soldier III: What's going on? Stand down, all of you!

Another soldier appears behind them, gun in one hand, whistle in the other, his fingers shaking.

Corvus: Go, Aima.

Aima: Y-Yes. Understood!

The stewardess tears off her eyepatch, revealing her other blood-red eye.

Before the whistle meets his lips, she leaps from the shadows, slamming into him.

Border Checkpoint Soldier III: Aargh! Get off me!

In a second, her arm snakes around his neck.

Border Checkpoint Soldier III: Uggh!

Aima: Apologies for the shock, but thank you for the gun and whistle.

The soldiers collapse.

Aima drags them to the corner, exhales, and pulls her eyepatch down.

Aima: No one will take you away, Annabelle, at least for the time being.

Aima: Hm? Why is everyone so quiet?

Passengers stare in slack-jawed silence. The girl runs up, tugging excitedly at her skirt.

Annabelle: Red eyes, fangs ... A-Are you a vampire too, Stewardess?

Aima: Oh. Well, yes, I am. But don't worry. It won't affect your service in any way whatsoever!

Annabelle: But your other eye is all clear and blue, like a lake, not red at all. How did you do that?

Aima: I-I'm not a pure-blood vampire.

She shakes her head quietly before looking away; she has no intention of going any deeper into the subject.

Semmelweis: I have to say, I didn't expect the stories of a vampire train to actually hold any truth. Though I doubt any of the stories had our vampires pouring tea and fluffing pillows.

Corvus: There was never any truth to them. Aima may be a vampire, yes, but she's never done anyone harm.

Semmelweis: Then, earlier, in the forest ...

She recalls the night in the snow, with the two of them pressed close together.

The storm was so thick she could barely see, only mist, trees, and a red scarf whipping in the wind.

Corvus: It was bloodthirst, so I gave her mine. It's an arrangement of ours.

Corvus adjusts the scarf around the small stewardess's neck.

Semmelweis: First a secret carriage, now a vampire stewardess. What else might you be hiding up your sleeve?

Corvus: Nothing of your concern. We share a common interest, so let us treat each other as comrades.

Corvus: There may be tricks up my sleeve, but for now, we watch, wait, and then strike.

Semmelweis: You surprise me more and more, Conductress. Comrades it is, but what's our next move?

Corvus: ...

Corvus: I wish there were some other way, old friend.

She exhales, a cold light flashing in her eyes.

Corvus: Aima, how many passengers are left on board?

Aima: I didn't count precisely; there were already quite a few that were taken to the detention room.

Aima: Oh! Conductress, are you going to ...

Corvus pushes through the crowd to a tall cabinet and yanks it open.

Corvus: You there. Ever handled a gun before?

Stowaways: Whoa ...

Weapons line the wall in neat rows, gleaming under the light.

Each one meticulously polished and ready, as if awaiting their call to battle.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: Yet another surprise. I don't think I ever would have expected you to be lugging an armory around with you.

Corvus: It's a hobby. Take this.

She takes a pistol down and tosses it to Semmelweis.

Corvus: Silver bullets are more effective than arcane skill when dealing with vampires and their Infected.

Corvus: Anyone old enough to handle a weapon, arm yourselves. We have a fierce battle ahead.

Friends in Need

CH31101-17

Damaged Carriage

Gunfire erupts. In less than half an hour, the train turns into a battlefield.

Semmelweis: Damn!

Semmelweis: The gunshots are drawing them in. We've got to close the door!

Corvus: Head to the next carriage. I'll close the door.

Corvus leaves cover and charges straight into the carnage.

Annabelle: Conductress, don't!

Corvus: Don't look back!

The weight of unseen eyes is unbearable. Annabelle turns her head.

Annabelle: ...!

Annabelle: I-I want to go home.

Corvus: ...

Corvus: I tried to warn you.

Semmelweis: There are too many of them. We can't do this alone.

Infected Passenger: Aaaargh ...

From outside, more Infected swarm in, spreading like a plague of locusts through every car.

Cries of panic and bloodlust rise and fall.

Semmelweis: We have enough ammunition but not enough hands to fire them.

Corvus: There is still one option left.

Corvus: There are more passengers. We can rally the people to fight.

Semmelweis: The other carriages are still under guard; I doubt we'll find many willing passengers who are still fit to join us.

Corvus: Hm. I know where to go. Pyrrhos gave me his word he would leave them be.

Semmelweis: And you still think he'll stand by it?

Corvus: It's our best chance. As for whether he has kept his promise ...

She steadies her breath, aiming at the door buckling under the assault.

Corvus: We're about to find out.

The Extra Carriage

Gunfire still rattles.

Another sound joins in—scattered, heavy footsteps.

Reyhan: One, two, three ... No, there are more. Many more.

Her voice trembles.

Reyhan: They don't sound like soldiers. What do we do, Yakov?

Yakov: ...

Yakov: Ready your weapons, everyone.

The steps draw closer. The lock strains.

Passengers grip their makeshift weapons, every eye fixed on the opening door.

Yakov: Hold. Now! Attack!

The mob surges, raining down blows without mercy.

Agitated Voice: Stop, damn it! We're here to help!

Young Voice: My dolly ... I can't find her.

Cries, curses, and wails crash together in a storm.

Yakov: Wait, wait! I heard the little girl! And-And a woman?

The little skirmish finds a belated end.

A makeshift militia appears before them, young and old bedecked in piecemeal gear.

Semmelweis: Everyone, please lower your weapons.

Semmelweis: There's really no need to be at each other's throats each time we meet.

Reyhan: It's that investigator. She's back. And the conductress!

Corvus steps forward, adjusting a tilted hat brim.

Corvus: Excellent, you're already prepared to protect yourselves.

Corvus: I'll make this short. The train is surrounded by vampire Infected. We need your help to defeat them and get moving again.

Corvus: Take a weapon if you're able. We'll fight together.

The stowaways and the passengers glance at one another. Silence holds for a moment.

Stowaway I: But, why us?

Stowaway I: Look around you. We're just a bunch of regular folk—refugees who've probably never even touched a gun. The army's here, isn't it? Shouldn't they clean up this mess?

Stowaway II: And say we risk our lives to save other people from these Infected, what would stop them from reporting us if we try to cross the border after?

Then voices rise again, questions sharp and insistent.

Stowaway I: She's right. I say we unload the carriages with the Infected inside, and the rest of us keep going to Budapest.

Reyhan: You're quiet, Yakov. What are you thinking?

A single soft query hushes the noise, all eyes turning to their leader.

Yakov: ...

Yakov: I'd say ...

Seating Carriage

The other isolation car is quieter.

Only distant gunfire breaks the silence, like the front line of war.

Sonya: This is all getting rather unnerving.

The woman sets down her porcelain cup in a rattle. Yet she maintains an utter state of composure.

Arbuthnot: Gunshots? Not another bleedin' war!

Arbuthnot: Hell. I knew I should've brought my gun.

The gentleman scans around them, his pupils twitching.

Verity: So this is it, my career's turning point—magazine editor turned combat correspondent.

The editor finally closes her notebook, moving to the door for a peek.

A bloody hand slaps against the window.

Infected Passenger: Oh ...

Passenger IV: Oh, my! What on earth is that?

Verity: More of those Infected? Wasn't aware you could mass-produce such a thing.

The editor peers out further, toward the soldiers' camp.

Men rush back and forth, shouting, waving, losing all sense of order.

Her eyes drift past them to a gray building. Figures burst out, shrieking, trailing blood across the snow.

Some wander into the forest; others charge toward the train.

Verity: That must be the station warehouse. Is that where these Infected are coming from?

Verity: It's only been two hours since the quarantine began. What's gone wrong?

The editor frowns; another scream rings sharp in her ear.

Stowaways: ...!

Sonya: Oh, heavens! I've never seen such a thing in all my life!

Arbuthnot: Ah? Oh.

Infected Passenger: Come ... in. Come.

Passenger IV: The door won't hold for long. Get something to block it!

Stowaways: Ah!

Verity: What are you all standing there for? Get out of the way.

Gunfire rattles. Dark red bursts bloom across the train windows.

Through the smoke, armed figures emerge, faces pale and bloodied.

Semmelweis: Ah. Think I strained my shoulder.

Corvus: I did warn you. Someone your size can't handle a shotgun.

Semmelweis: Well, you can hardly expect me to take them down one by one with a pistol.

Verity: If this is some kind of robbery, then I'm afraid you'll be disappointed. A writer always travels light.

Corvus: It isn't. We want your help.

Corvus: That is all we know. Most of the soldiers stationed here have been infected. Many passengers have become their captives.

Corvus: It's thanks to their help that we made it this far.

She nods toward the refugees beside her.

Yakov: Just repaying a favor. Think nothing of it.

Yakov: She's helped so many people get to Budapest and asked for nothing in return. She'll have our support no matter what.

Passenger III: An extra carriage.

Passenger IV: They look like they just climbed straight out of the trenches or something.

They whisper uneasily. To them, these unkempt and unruly strangers with rifles look no less monstrous than the creatures they had vanquished.

Sonya: Well, in any case, we appreciate you rescuing us.

Sonya: Once we arrive, I'll be sure to arrange for gifts to be sent your way.

Yakov: That won't be necessary, ma'am. Just stay close, and we'll get out of here together.

Sonya: Pardon my confusion. You mean to say we're to leave this carriage?

Corvus: Yes. We need to see if any of the passengers are still alive.

Stowaways: What?!

Passenger III: You're not seriously asking us to fight those soldiers, are you? Infected soldiers, even!

The noise doesn't stop. In the chaos, a child squeezes out from the crowd.

Ivanushka: Um, Ms. Conductress, is Rubuska there, too? I still haven't seen her.

Before Corvus can reply, another voice cuts in.

Passenger IV: Rubuska ... You mean that fake vampire? She was one of the first ones they took away.

Ivanushka: Fake vampire? But she has red eyes and pointy teeth.

Annabelle: Don't listen to her! Rubuska is a real vampire!

Annabelle: Are you one of her familiars too? Come on, let's rescue her together!

Ivanushka: Yes, let's!

Ivanushka: She protected us. I have to pay her back. We pinky promised.

Sonya: Hmph, children. Aren't you afraid of those monsters outside?

Ivanushka & Annabelle: Never!

The bold, if childlike, answer surprises everyone.

Reyhan: Haha, see? Even the kids have got more guts than you.

Sonya: You ...

Arbuthnot: It ain't that we're tryin' to get out of helpin', but we ain't got no weapons. What d'you expect us to do, fight 'em off with knives an' forks?

Corvus: No need to worry about that.

She shifts aside, opening a path for her ally.

Aima steps forward, loosening a heavy sack, which pours out rifles and pistols into a motley assortment like a fisherman displaying his catch.

Aima: Take any you like. All the guns here are quite easy to handle. I picked them out myself.

Arbuthnot: An FN Model 1910! And this is a Mosin–Nagant! And a Mauser C96!

The gentleman lunges into the pile with boyish glee.

Arbuthnot: This one's excellent—consistent firepower. But this beauty, she's got a smoother pump cycle—lovely for follow-up shots.

Sonya: *sigh* Will the fighting ever cease?

The old woman sighs, then hardens. Her gaze turns ice-cold.

Sonya: Alright, just pick one for me. Something with some punch!

Blood of My Blood

CH31101-18

Against the rattle of gunfire outside, the warehouse seems unnervingly quiet.

Warehouse, Nika Checkpoint

The vampire's invitation still awaits a response. The girl bows her head, staring at her shadow.

Pyrrhos: Let me remind you that, although my life may be everlasting, my patience is not.

Pyrrhos: I have to say, your hesitation is disappointing.

Rubuska: ...

Rubuska: What's this going to cost me?

She looks into his crimson eyes.

Rubuska: Every time I've been offered any kind of gift in my life, every time I've even come close to something ...

Rubuska: It's either been taken away from me or turned out to be a complete fraud.

Rubuska: So, sir, which one is it?

Pyrrhos: Neither. Because I'm not offering you any "gifts," only an alternative reality.

Pyrrhos: All it takes is a drop of blood and a little bravery, because there's a good chance you'll end up just like them.

He lifts a limp arm, waving it at her mockingly.

Pyrrhos: A small ask, I'm sure, for someone such as yourself.

Pyrrhos: What's a little risk when your dreams are so very close? This is what you want, isn't it?

He stands by the window, hand reaching for her.

Rubuska: Yes, I crave it.

Dizziness grips her. A sudden, crushing tide of "fortune" crashes over Rubuska.

Stone, walls, cargo ... everything melts away.

She stands in the middle of the cemetery under a blood moon.

Yes, the same damp cemetery her mother described a thousand times.

Before her looms the vampire, Pyrrhos, cloaked in black like an ageless shadow.

Pyrrhos: I can read it in your eyes.

Pyrrhos: The urge, the desire—an eagerness to embrace the stillness of the dark and be rid of all your mortal troubles.

Pyrrhos: And here I am, your wish-maker. Come to send you to the sweet cradle of night or of death.

Moonlight spills over his face. His red eyes overflowing. Blood, corpses, and the reek of death reflecting in them.

She sees more than that; their dead eyes meet hers in the reflection.

"Choose!" They whisper.

You cannot refuse us, just as you cannot refuse your past.

Pyrrhos: Well? What do you say?

Rubuska: ...

Faces flicker before her—mother, father, brother, and comrades.

It is a chance to see them again. How could she refuse?

Rubuska: Yes.

Detention Room

Children: Rubuska!

Annabelle: She's not here.

Armed men storm in, but the familiar figure is gone.

Blood stains the floor, still warm, trailing like a serpent.

Semmelweis: There are drag marks. Seems they've transferred some of the captives.

Yellow light cuts across the room. Shadows twitch in the corners. A familiar voice whimpers faintly.

Little William: *whimper* Home. I just want to go home.

Dorothy: It's alright, child. I'm here with you. We'll be fine.

Annabelle: William! Ms. Dorothy!

Annabelle rushes forward, clutching her long-lost kin.

Dorothy: Don't! There's—

Shadows lunge from the opposite corner.

???: Arrrrgh!

Corvus: Prepare for battle!

Detention Room

Infected Soldier: *coughing*

The soldier crumples, eyes bloodshot, veins crawling like creeping vines across his temple.

Corvus: Where's Pyrrhos? Where did he take the girl?

She seizes him by his bloody collar.

Infected Soldier: W-Warehouse. At the station. Lots of ... Lots of them there ...

He coughs, words slurred, gurgling.

Corvus: Did he do this to you?

Infected Soldier: Yes ...

He gasps, then smiles strangely.

Infected Soldier: It's too late.

Corvus: What? Speak up.

Rubuska: Ah ...

A cry rises in the distance.

It is long, ecstatic, weary, like a bird to its nest, a ship finding shore.

Aima: It's Rubuska! That sound—Is she ...

Infected Soldier: Argh. It's too late. Soon ...

Infected Soldier: Your friend will be a vampire! Hahahahaha ...

He laughs until bloody tears streak his face. In his throat, he releases a stream of broken whispers, another voice takes over.

Infected Soldier: Gushing, seething, a torrent red. We, the cattle, a plague we spread.

Infected Soldier: We are the spawn, the vampire's aide, to turn this earth a crimson shade.

Infected Soldier: The "Storm" forms as it did before.

Infected Soldier: No wars, no conflict—nevermore!

A gunshot. Blood sprays.

Corvus lowers her weapon, her stitched face grave.

Arbuthnot: Ah. He's even turned his own army. It's no wonder these Infected are crawlin' all over the place.

Semmelweis: "The 'Storm' forms ..."

She crouches, inspecting the corpse with an investigator's eye.

Semmelweis: Something's been off since the beginning. The symptoms have taken hold too rapidly. There has never been a recorded instance of the infection spreading so fast.

Semmelweis: Look here. Burst veins, pupils so dilated they almost cover the entire iris. The infection's been accelerated.

Semmelweis: In other words, these are no regular Infected. They're the failed product of a different kind of transformation.

Corvus: One task at a time.

Corvus: Come. We need to find Rubuska.

Moments earlier ...

Pyrrhos: Well? What do you say?

Rubuska: Yes.

Pyrrhos: Very good. I knew you'd come to your senses.

Satisfied with the answer, he offers a sharp, beastly smile.

Pyrrhos: Come child. It's time to leave the ugly trappings of mortality behind you.

Pyrrhos: Once we have the same blood pulsing through our veins ...

Pyrrhos: We will build a new world, united in death.

This is the "bloodline" she has longed for.

Rubuska: Мама, Dad, Kolyo.

An echo of her childhood.

Rubuska: I'll protect you.

Tugging at the shreds of her surviving faith.

Rubuska: Till the end of time.

The next second, shadows surge like a black tide.

Pyrrhos: Hm? A shadow?

Pyrrhos: Uggh!

Pyrrhos: You ... Why?

Rubuska: I want to be a vampire more than anything I've ever wanted.

Rubuska: To have the power to save the people I love from death.

Rubuska: To be the one to protect and provide.

Rubuska: But I never want to be like you! I may have red eyes and fangs, but I don't want to lie and manipulate to get what I want!

Pyrrhos: Ugh!

Rubuska: Heh. Did you really think I'd just surrender? That I'd take the easy way out? My family wants me to live.

Rubuska: So, I'll live, damn it! Live until the smoke clears and the sky turns blue again, till the rain puts out the fires and the primroses bloom in the forests of Strandzha!

Rubuska: I'll live till my friends grow old and gray and wrinkly, till my family comes back!

Rubuska: I'll live! We'll all live!

Rubuska: And you—you will rot in your grave!

Rubuska: You wretched bastard!

The true vampire convulses on the floor, his chest heaving like an old bellows.

Rubuska: I did it. I killed him.

Rubuska: It's over.

Rubuska settles on the floor, feeling her heart pounding louder and louder.

Rubuska: Have to get back to the train. Have to tell them.

She scrambles back up and staggers toward the door. She knows her friends are still waiting.

sound of attacking

Before she can cry out, her body is flung through the air and slams to the ground.

Pyrrhos: Heh. Don't tell me you believe those bedtime stories?

Pyrrhos stands, his face twisted into a grotesque look of sinister joy.

Rubuska: How? You-You should've ...

Pyrrhos: Died? *tut* Don't be absurd. Listening to that silly little speech was more painful than any stake to the chest.

Pyrrhos: Let me guess, you brought holy water and garlic, too?

He looms over the girl, dismissing her attempt with a wave of his hand.
An unseen shadow coils around her throat, tightening, then tightening again.

Pyrrhos: Those legends were merely that—naught but childish forgeries, just like you, little "vampire."

Rubuska: No ...

Pyrrhos: Oh, what a waste of time you turned out to be. I truly believed you might share my vision.

Pyrrhos: But, alas, you're just as narrow-minded as the rest of them.

Pyrrhos: I suppose it's time you found your place in the dirt. If you're lucky, someone might bring you back someday, then you can act out your little "noble-hearted vampire" charade once more.

Her vision blurs.

The moon, streaks of blood, the cemetery ... everything that once made up her childhood crumbles to ruin.

And with it, her dreams of becoming a vampire.

Look! Her shadow—it's moving!

You're a real vampire, right, Rubuska?

Rubuska: It's not a lie.

She closes her eyes, arms slack at her sides, bloodlike tears trailing down her face.

The door bursts open from a weighty kick.

Footsteps ring out, steady, strong, then faster, faster.

A hail of bullets tears through the vampire's shoulder.

Pyrrhos: Ugh!

Pyrrhos releases her before melting into shadow.

Air floods back into her lungs. A familiar tall figure comes into focus.

Corvus: Rubuska.

She crouches to reach the girl; glimpses of relief and concern pass over her patchwork face.

Corvus: Finally. We've found you.

"Us" · 1/2

CH31101-19

My blood flows across the city, as fresh from a battlefield,

It rises as the tide, seeping into the empty gaps between cobblestones,

Quenching the parched mouths of man and beast,

And engulfing the world in its sanguine embrace.

— Charles Baudelaire, The Fountain of Blood

Warehouse, Nika Checkpoint

Children: Rubuska!

A surge of friendly faces rushes to Rubuska's side, surrounding her.

Rubuska: What-What're you doing here? I-I thought you'd never wanna speak to me again.

Annabelle: That's not true. We like you, even if you aren't a real vampire.

Little William: We saw it all! Whack! You put a big old stake right through the monster's chest! So you're not a vampire. You're even stronger!

The crowd closes in on Rubuska, their warmth flushing her cheeks red.

Rubuska: ...

Rubuska: Thank you.

Pyrrhos: Ah, the joy of reunion. How very touching. In fact, why don't we drink to it?

From the corner comes a sinister voice, drawing eyes and muzzles in its direction.

Semmelweis: Those are ...

Corpses by the dozens piled high into a nauseating hill of flesh.

The surface layer rots away, exposing pale-gray sinew, entrails dangling in tangles, blood oozing down like a sticky mire.

Pyrrhos sits atop the mound, lounging.

Corvus: The bodies of the passengers, and the soldiers too.

Pyrrhos: Is that all you see? *tut* You never did have an eye for detail, Iglika.

His sharp grin deepens.

Pyrrhos: Look closer. Your Foundation friend might find a little surprise.

Semmelweis: ...!

The investigator spots familiar checkered uniforms and marks among the heap.

Semmelweis: Squad 77. All of them.

Pyrrhos: Indeed. I worried they'd prove irksome if not dealt with, so I handled them before they even boarded the train.

Dark red eyes sweep past her with casual indifference.

Pyrrhos: Though it seems one managed to slip her way on board.

Corvus: Why, Pyrrhos? I need a reason.

Pyrrhos: ...

Pyrrhos: If you must ask, Iglika, it's because I've run out of patience.

Pyrrhos: People and their endless games, wars one after another, and following it—exile and despair.

Pyrrhos: And do you know where it all began?

He hoists a limp arm; blood streams down it like a red river.

Pyrrhos: Blood. Too many bloodlines are bound to this land, each serving their own desires.

Pyrrhos: For centuries, they have nipped and snapped at each other, unable to cooperate, unwilling to unite, never satisfied with peace.

Pyrrhos: I tried to break them free from this cycle—did everything I could, including joining the Liberation Front.

Corvus: You could've told me this. We could've talked about it.

Pyrrhos: Oh, I could have, Iglika, but why use words when it is already clear to see?

Pyrrhos: Don't you hear it? When you close your eyes at night, don't you feel the distant tremors of their cries?

Pyrrhos: After you left the Liberation Front, after all others had forgotten how to even speak of our cause ...

Pyrrhos: A voice came to me. A voice from the heavens. She heard my prayers and showed me a new path.

He gestures toward the mound of bodies, eyes blazing.

Pyrrhos: A path of unity! Where all would share the same blood, the same interest, the same goal.

sound of attacking

At the crack of gunfire, Pyrrhos vanishes, the shot clipping only a few fluttering bats.

In only a heartbeat, he reappears soundlessly behind Corvus.

Pyrrhos: Another bullet. You wound me in more ways than one, Iglika.

Corvus: You've lost your way, Pyrrhos. Do you truly think blood is to blame for all of this?

Corvus: It's one cause of conflict, yes, but so are misunderstanding, fear, even love.

Corvus: To blame everything on bloodlines means choosing a simple lie over a complicated truth.

Pyrrhos: Haha, you haven't thought deeply enough then, dear Iglika. Look at these causes, examine them at the root, and what do you find, hm? Human nature.

Pyrrhos: And our nature, old friend, is set by our blood.

The vampire spreads his arms before the hill of flesh, his maddened eyes ablaze with baleful violence.

Pyrrhos: Listen to me! Imagine a world with no bloodshed,

Pyrrhos: where everyone is free of mortal weakness and given infinite time to enjoy the pleasures of this earth.

Pyrrhos: Our shared bloodline serving as a bond, not a line of division, so that all our hearts might beat as one.

Pyrrhos: Race, color, creed—all would melt away in the face of this great family we will create.

Pyrrhos: Was that not your vision once, Iglika?

Corvus: You want a world without bloodshed? Hah. Ironic. Your methods tell a different story.

Corvus: Look around you, Pyrrhos. You're starting a war, not ending one.

Corvus: Unity, really? Things didn't go your way, so now you'll drag us all to hell along with you.

Pyrrhos: ...

Moonlight strips away all pretense, casting a pallid veil across his face.

Pyrrhos: You always did know how to use those words like a scalpel.

Pyrrhos: *sigh* I was a fool to think you'd stand with me again.

He sighs, turning his eyes with strange softness toward the stewardess.

Pyrrhos: Aima.

Pyrrhos: Come. This battle will be fierce, and I won't allow my blood to come to harm.

Semmelweis: His blood? She's ...

Semmelweis darts her eyes from face to face, loose threads knitting in her mind.

Aima steps forward as every eye turns to her.

Aima: Uncle Pyrrhos ...

Rubuska: Aima!

A voice calls out from behind, and she halts.

She looks back, the woolly red scarf brushing her cheek.

She grips it tight, slowly and firmly locking with her uncle's eyes.

Aima: Forgive me, Uncle. I love you dearly, and I'm grateful for all you've done. But I can't.

Aima: You know how much the "Danube Dawn" means to me. Please, stop. I don't want anyone else to get hurt.

She steps back to stand proud and defiant among her people.

Pyrrhos: Blood of my blood. Of all people, you choose to stand against me. And you ...

Men, women, the old, the young ... each stands ready from a measured distance, brimming with fear, disgust, and scorn.

They build a silent wall, cutting him off. Beneath it yawns a chasm no words could ever cross.

Pyrrhos: Hahahahaha. You look at me like I'm some kind of monster!

He laughs with a twitch, then inhales deeply and resumes his malevolent composure.

Pyrrhos: Well, I tried, but I always knew preaching would only get me so far.

Pyrrhos: Violence, religion, politics, marriage ... Our predecessors sought every means to unite us, but greed has always been stronger.

Pyrrhos: Still, I was naive enough to hope we'd finally put aside our differences.

Pyrrhos: Ruins, battlefields, countless headstones, and beneath every one, a blood debt unpaid. Hah ... Hahaha ...

Pyrrhos: Perhaps, in the end, you were right, Iglika. If I can't have what I want ...

He reaches to pull out the wooden stake lodged in his chest.

Fleshy bat wings sprout from his back, spreading wide to block out the hazy moonlight outside the window.

Pyrrhos: Then I will drag every single man, woman, and child.

Pyrrhos: **To hell.**

The monster lets out a shrill cry, eyes streaming blood.

The sound spreads through the night like a deadly signal, drawing hordes of the Infected in from the dark.

Infected Passenger: Gushing, seething!

Infected Soldier: Nevermore!

Semmelweis: The Infected are swarming. He must have called for them.

Corvus: Incoming! Weapons ready!

Corvus: Pyrrhos. I will put a bullet through your heart myself.

No More Talks of "Humanitarianism"

小径

The Infected Transformation Experiment Record

No.■■

Date: ■■■■.■■.■■
Recorder: /

1. Objective:
To study the effects of specific environmental stimuli, (particularly audio patterns, i.e. "the Song"), on the blood samples of the Infected, with a focus on their temporary mutation and fusion behavior.

2. Method Summary:
· Collect four samples each from arcanist subjects (Group B) and human subjects (Group C), forming one experimental unit. Three units per group are used as control and stimulus sets.
· Acquire high-activity vampire blood samples (Group A).
· Under ■■■■■ conditions, expose Group B and C to Group A to ■■■■■.
· Introduce "the Song" as the primary stimulus source.
· Monitor Groups B and C in real time for changes.

...
.....

4. Key Observations (Experiment Iterations 7–■■):
· Temporary Fusion and Mutation: Recipient samples (Groups B and C) exhibited the base arcanum traits of the source vampire post-fusion, confirming transformation into the Infected.
· "Song" Effect: Confirmed that exposure to "the Song" significantly increases transformation

probability. (Fusion rate averaged ■.■% without stimulus, rising to ■■.■% under stimulus.)
· Extreme Rejection Response: All test subjects died rapidly following successful fusion and manifestation of ability.

.....
...

Note: Research will and must continue. If this succeeds, we may be able to turn ordinary humans into arcanists.

Bad Luck

小径

Blood-Stained 0073-MV

Mission Number: 0073-MV

Date: ■■■■.■■.■■

Got the file on the new colleague today—Semmelweis. According to her record, she's a sharp, calm, and reliable investigator. With her joining us, this "odd" case should go a lot smoother. Still, before she arrives, Squad 77 has to do its part—at least handle the groundwork properly. Can't have her looking down on us. I think I've got a lead. Been stationed here for a while, and I keep hearing rumors about that so-called mystic train. You'd be hard-pressed to find another line with so many vampire stories attached to it, unless you're in one of ■■■■'s horror novels. The conductress never replies to our messages—not to inquiries, columns, or even official investigation requests. Highly suspicious. On my list, that puts it right at the top—extremely, ridiculously suspicious! (Suspect there's a syntax error here. Recommend revision before submission.)

(I struck out your irrelevant rambling. Why do you always fill task logs with random digressions and pointless jokes?)
(Okay, fine. Thanks. But you know this is just a draft — I'll rewrite the official report later.)
(Then stop wasting the report forms. I couldn't even find a blank one last time and had to draw the format by hand ... I'll stake out the station tomorrow and see what I can learn about this "Danube Dawn.")

Date: ■■■■.■■.■■

Did we just hit the jackpot? Officer Pyrrhos from the Nika checkpoint invited us to "talk." Guess our "covert" investigation wasn't so covert after all—or maybe the man's just sharp as hell. After getting the invite, first thing I did was review our recent operation. I wouldn't say flawless, but definitely clean ... Uh, in the formal report maybe I'll write that we "intentionally leaked intel to lure them in." Depends how it plays out.

Anyway, is it trap or cooperation? We'll only know once we go. Damn, I'm actually nervous. But the invite was polite ... and honestly, our investigation has been stalling. So yeah, let's go! I'm a proud member of Squad 77! My record's just as good as Semmelweis's, I'm just terrible at paperwork!
Date: ■■■■.■■.■■

Warehouse address: ■■■■■■■■■■■■ stench heavy blood ■■■■■■■■ Invited by Officer Pyrrhos of Nika checkpoint we ■■■ him ■■■■■■■■ he's behind me he's searching ■■■■■■■ this crate is a terrible hiding spot ■■■■

"Us" · 2/2

CH31101-19

Cemetery at Dusk

Villager I: Is the beast still breathing? Hey, you!

Young Pyrrhos: ...

Villager I: Devil take him, he's still twitching, even after we staked him and left him under the sun for a week. He ought to be dust by now.

Villager I: The last one didn't last but three days. This one must be of purer blood. They say those are stronger.

Young Pyrrhos: W-Why ...

Young Pyrrhos: I never ... hurt ... any of you ...

Villager II: Haha. What's that? Why? 'Cause you're a vampire, a monster.

Villager II: What, so we've got to wait until you've drained someone dry before we put you down, do we?

The sunlight burns him until he can no longer raise his eyes. He shrinks his neck, attempting to turn his head in vain.

A vampire's hunt is a bloody one, as always. Human, beast, vampire—blood spills in a tangled mess across the ground, merging into a stream that soaks his toes.

A breeze stirs, carrying a distant song.

The song is ethereal and light, as if drifting from a vast, boundless space, weaving into a comforting net that rises and falls.

Sing-Song Voice: Despair.

Sing-Song Voice: The purest of emotions. It lifts the weight of fear, frees you from the constraints of mundanity, and brings you one step closer to perfection.

Young Pyrrhos: Who ...?

He smells and hears the crisp, cool wind.

Sing-Song Voice: I am your wish-maker.

Young Pyrrhos: ...

Young Pyrrhos: "Wish" ... My wish ...

Sing-Song Voice: You need not speak it; the wind has whispered it to me.

Sing-Song Voice: I shall help you achieve greatness, and you will be surrounded by family and friends, never to be alone again.

Sing-Song Voice: And all this will bring you ever closer to perfection, for you will be awoken to your emotions, to perfect passion.

Young Pyrrhos: Family. Yes, I ...

Young Pyrrhos: I want them ... With me ... evermore.

Warehouse, Nika Checkpoint

Pyrrhos: Ever ... more ...

The monster shrinks back into human form, like a withered cocoon trembling in the corner, gasping for breath.

His neck is torn open, dark blood flowing out like a spring.

Pyrrhos: Iglika.

Corvus: I'm here.

His old comrade stands before him in silence. The space between them is not far, and yet it spans a fathomless deep.

Pyrrhos: Is it over?

Corvus: It is, Pyrrhos.

Pyrrhos: Do you remember our old rallying cry?

Pyrrhos: "In hope, we stand as one." Hmph. Yet here we are.

Pyrrhos: Do you still believe in it?

Corvus: I've never doubted it. I still feel the power of those words.

Corvus: And tonight, I feel its presence stronger than ever.

Not on the battlefield, nor in a field of slaughter, nor in hollow declarations. It lives in every moment, here and now.

Corvus: It lives inside each of us.

Pyrrhos: ...

Pyrrhos: Then you've found the right path. And I-I've strayed too far.

Pyrrhos: Go on, Iglika. Do it.

Pyrrhos: I hope you live to see that dream come true.

Corvus: You've had your war, Pyrrhos. But ours goes on.

Corvus: Still, the end will come in time.

Maybe not today. Maybe not tomorrow.

But one day, a generation will refuse to raise their guns, refuse to trade blood for fleeting victory.

When that day comes, the Danube will flow in peace once more, and lilacs will bloom again over the ruins of Belgrade.

Corvus: When it does, we'll ring the peace bell so loud that all those who rest in the earth hear it.

She lowers her weapon, turns on her heel, and walks away.

Corvus: Farewell, Pyrrhos.

Long Dark Night · 1/2

CH31101-20

Aima: Uncle Pyrrhos, how much farther do we need to go? I'm feeling a little dizzy.

Pyrrhos: Not long now. The border's just on the other side of the mountain. We'll be there soon.

Pyrrhos: Then we'll cross the Lech to Ms. Valentina's castle.

Pyrrhos: And she'll cure you. She'll make things right.

Aima: But how do you know she'll help?

Pyrrhos: I just know, Aima. A vampire always stands by her people. It's in our blood.

Aima: In our blood.

Pyrrhos: You'll do well to remember that, Aima.

Pyrrhos: There is no bond stronger than blood.

Aima: Uncle ...

Aima gently sets the wooden matryoshka down.

Its painted smile is unchanged, as if it still remembers the winds along the Danube, the swaying of the train, the murmurs and laughter of her journey.

Now its journey has come to an end.

It should return to where it belongs, a world without walls, without exile.

Perhaps there it will find its answer.

Aima: Goodbye.

Warehouse, Nika Checkpoint

Infected Soldier: Ooogh ... Argh ...

Their leader gone, the monsters prowl restlessly, their roars ripping through the silent snowbound night.

Inside the warehouse, the survivors gather to plan their next move.

Semmelweis: Signal's back. I've contacted the Foundation; they're sending reinforcements immediately.

Semmelweis: But by the looks of it, the Infected will get to us before the backup arrives.

Corvus: It seems Pyrrhos's death hasn't had any effect on them. They're still coming.

Corvus: Perhaps, if anything, they seem more dangerous.

Semmelweis holds a glance on the shuddering doors of the warehouse, letting out an audible sigh.

Semmelweis: ...

Semmelweis: After this, mark my words, this is the last time I take on a mission with vampires.

Watching the situation unfold, Yakov looks down at the weapon in his hands, frowning.

Yakov: We're running out of bullets. What do we do?

Corvus: We have to take them down. All at once.

Yakov: All at once? How?

Corvus: Draw them into a room, and leave the rest to those.

She points toward a number of heavy crates bearing an ominous marking: "flammable."

Semmelweis: I noticed them when we entered, too. Explosives, I presume?

Corvus: Yes. Pyrrhos mentioned having seized them from a militia camp.

Arbuthnot: Sounds like a plan. But how do we draw 'em close enough?

Sonya: This isn't a plan; this is madness! Do you seriously believe they'll simply saunter into a building as if it were some kind of concert?

Rubuska: Concert? That's it! We'll play music! Lucky for us, I always carry my kaval with me.

Her ruby eyes sparkle with sudden inspiration as she lifts her flute.

Rubuska: In the old stories, when the Infected go loopy like this, they're easily attracted to loud noises.

Rubuska: And my kaval—well, let's just say, if you've got ears, you'll hear it.

Semmelweis: That matches with documentation I've read in the Foundation archives—a feasible solution.

Semmelweis: But that would make you the bait. Are you certain you can do it?

Rubuska grips her flute with determination.

Rubuska: Of course.

Reyhan: We can't; she's just a child.

Annabelle: Don't go, Rubuska. We nearly lost you once already.

She squeezes her doll.

Rubuska: Don't worry. I can handle it. I run fast. Those Infected won't get close. Besides ...

Rubuska: Me and my kaval can control shadows. I'll make a whole bunch of them as a distraction.

Rubuska: See, tell me, who else could pull that off?

One by one, the others shake their heads. Worry and refusal are written across every face, save one.

Corvus: You're not afraid?

Rubuska: I'd be lying if I said no.

Rubuska: But I'm Rubuska, the all-powerful, the deathless! And you're all counting on me!

Corvus nods, offering her a knowing smile.

Corvus: Then go. I believe in you, "old pal."

Rubuska: See you when this is all over!

She straightens her back and salutes clumsily. Corvus pretends not to see, merely turning away and waving to the others.

Corvus: The rest of you, come with me. Time to set the trap.

Corvus: There is no room for failure.

Border Checkpoint

Snow still falls.

Infected Soldier: Ooh ... Argh ...

Infected trudge through the whipping snow, moving step by heavy step.

Rubuska: ...

The girl stands alone, her only companion the wooden flute in her hands.

Infected Soldier: Arrah ...

Faces rise from the darkness, pale skin clinging to bone, veins etched across them like dry riverbeds.

And in them, she sees another face.

Rubuska: ...!

She steps back once, then forward twice.

Rubuska: Мама, forgive me.

Rubuska: But I'm not running anymore.

The great Rubuska takes a deep breath. Lips meet the waiting flute.

It starts with a few clumsy notes, followed by a jumble of uneven chords. But the chords soon weave together, and the melody resonates up through the biting cold.

Infected Passenger: Oooh ... Arraagh ...

It is a soft, lonesome tune, one that once carried her through battlefields that had gone quiet, graveyards, and mountains.

Through long years, she was the melody's only listener.

Back then, all she saw was silence stretching to the horizon and futures unseen.

So she recited tale after tale of vampires.

"Dracula the Vampire": Before you stands the forefather of young Rubuska—Dracula the Impaler!

"Arnold the Vampire": And I, her noble grandfather, the glorious First Duke of Arges!

"Savonovic the Vampire": And I ...

That lineage, growing ever more tangled, became her closest companion on the road.

When she comes to, she realizes just how far she has wandered.

Rubuska: Мама!

Mother: You've come so far, my Buska.

Rubuska: Yes, I have.

Rubuska: I crossed the Rila Mountains, waded through-through the Struma River, and traveled along the Danube.

Rubuska: Oh, I even rode a train!

Mother: You sound happy, my dear girl.

Rubuska: Happy?

Mother: Those sights you've seen, your new friends, the train. I can feel your joy.

Rubuska: ...

In the fading flute's descent, the last note melts into the sunlight.

She tilts her face upward, as if catching the April wind once more.

Rubuska: Yes, I am happy.

Rubuska: Happier than I've been in a long time, Мама.

Semmelweis: She's done it. The Infected are swarming together.

Corvus: Explosives are in place. On my mark.

Corvus waves toward Rubuska.

She instantly understands, slipping out from the shadows until she is free of the Infected's encirclement.

All is ready. The conductress narrows her gaze and gives the final order.

Corvus: Three, two, one.

Third-Rate Novel

小径

An Ordinary Yet Unordinary Story

Today's tale doesn't start with "once upon a time." It begins in "a quiet, ordinary village." In that village lived an equally ordinary little girl whose father was a vampire. But unlike him, she didn't live apart from humans. She felt a natural fondness toward both humans and arcanists. Perhaps because she was a hybrid—an "impure" half-vampire? In any case, for a long while, the girl lived peacefully with her parents.

Until a shell fell.

Yes, war. Again.

War brings death, and death spreads. Her family didn't escape it; one by one, they died. Only she and her uncle survived, wandering endlessly. But shells don't discriminate. Human, arcanist, vampire, or half-breed—none are spared. The girl was wounded. How badly? No one knows. Severe enough that she nearly died. Her uncle wanted to save her—his only remaining family. Even if it meant making a deal with the devil, he would.

He carried her to an old castle. Its mistress, as all stories go, was powerful and mysterious. She healed the dying hybrid girl. The price—if it could even be called that—was an overactive regenerative power that let her recover from any wound with ease.

Since then, the girl's body has always been wrapped in bandages.

Long Dark Night · 2/2

CH31101-20

Border Checkpoint

Aima: Please form a line and await registration.

Aima: The train will leave at dawn, so please make good use of your time.

Order is at last restored.

The conductress remains behind, watching the snowy way station and the wreckage left by the blast. Blood, organs, and fragments carpet the snow, like scarlet flowers blooming in an instant.

Pyrrhos's corpse is brought forth. Laid at the center of the bloom, his hollow eyes stare into the void.

Corvus: This chill in the air ...

Corvus: The last time I felt a cold like this was in Strandzha. I thought it would be the end of me.

Corvus: We were hiding out in the mountains. Every gust of wind felt like icy teeth biting into us.

Snowflakes land in her palm. Soon they will melt away like breath into the cold air.

Corvus: *sigh* Aima will continue to work on the "Danube Dawn."

Corvus: Who would ever suspect a gentle girl like her of being a vampire? She'll be able to live a quiet life.

Corvus: She'll need blood from time to time, and I will provide it.

She mutters to herself, then frowns, glancing to the side.

Corvus: ...

Corvus: I see you over there. Come out.

Verity: Eyes as sharp as ever, I see. Nothing escapes you.

Corvus: Do I know you?

Verity: Do you know me? *mocking chuckle* We were partners.

Verity: That is, until you were lost to us in that accident.

Corvus: I think you have me confused, madam.

Verity: Heh ...

She sighs deeply.

Verity: Indeed. How unfortunate that the similarities only go skin deep.

Corvus: ...

Verity: Still, who's to say it wasn't a cruel twist of fate that I boarded your train? Because ...

Verity: In a way, we both lost someone today.

She takes the torch from the conductress's hand, lights it, and casts it on the scattered flesh before them.

The flames rise with a low and crisp murmur.

The two stand together speechless for a time, until the first light of dawn spills across the ground.

Verity: Dawn at last. It's been a long night.

Corvus: Time to go.

She turns toward the train, still halted, waiting like a slumbering iron giant.

Corvus: The "Danube Dawn" is ready to set off once again.

A Land Under the Sun

CH31101-21

The bloody night is over.

The train pushes west, weaving across snowy fields as it follows the path of the Danube.

Only when they spy the Széchenyi Chain Bridge shimmering over the river do they realize their ordeal is over.

Stowaways: Budapest!

Train Station, Budapest

Aima: We are now arriving at Budapest Keleti station. Please gather your belongings and form an orderly line.

The stewardess maintains order on the platform, pale cheeks touched with the golden morning light.

Verity: Hm. Thank you for an unforgettable journey.

Verity: I don't believe I've ever gathered so much useful material in a single trip. I'm almost tempted to write a novel.

Verity: If ever you take to writing or simply have some thoughts to share, do write in. Our pay is quite generous.

She passes a card to the stewardess.

Verity: Here. Our contact details. I hope to hear from you soon.

Aima: UTTU Magazine, Editor-in-Chief, Pandora Wilson. UTTU? What an unusual name.

When she lifts her head again, the crowd surges by, and Verity is nowhere to be seen.

Aima: Hm?

Aima stares down blankly until a loud cheer pulls her back.

Rubuska: Goodbye, Madam Sonya! Goodbye, Mr. Yakov! And you, Mr. Arbuthnot, sir!

Annabelle: No, don't say "goodbye"!

Ivanushka: *sob* You promise you'll write to us?

Children cling to Rubuska, unwilling to part.

Rubuska: Cross my heart. And I'll send gifts. Christmas, birthdays, the whole lot!

Annabelle: R-Really? Can I have a ruby eyeball for Thanksgiving and vampire fangs for Halloween?

Little William: Oh, me too! Me too!

Dorothy: Such naughty children! Who taught you it was appropriate to demand gifts from others like that?

The governess's stern scolding is drowned out by their joyous shouts.

Dorothy: I do apologize. I don't know where their manners have gone.

Rubuska: *chuckle* No need to worry, ma'am. I'd love to send them some things. It would make me more than happy.

Dorothy: ...

Dorothy: You're very kind, Ms. Rubuska. I'll be sure they prepare something for you in return.

Bidding farewell to the chattering children, Rubuska lets out a long-held breath.

Rubuska: Right, now I really need to work hard. Ruby eyes and fangs don't pay for themselves.

Semmelweis: I may have some errands from the Foundation that would suit you, if you're willing.

Semmelweis: I won't say they'll be easy, but they pay well.

Rubuska: Y-You mean it?

Semmelweis: Of course. Now that the three of you are registered with the Foundation, you're free to lead your lives as you wish.

Semmelweis: That includes deciding who you'll work for.

Corvus: Is that all? Your procedures were quicker than I expected.

Aima: F-For a moment, I thought you'd take us away to the Foundation and lock us up.

Semmelweis: I admit I did toss the idea around.

Girls: Huh?!

Semmelweis: But after a thorough investigation, I regret to say ...

She blinks with the flash of a secret smile.

Semmelweis: That our intelligence was faulty.

Semmelweis: There are no vampires aboard the "Danube Dawn." It's safe to dismiss the reports as no more than a rumor.

Rubuska: Oh, real funny, "boss." You nearly gave me a heart attack!

The girls' laughter drifts up, then scatters into the tide of people.

Semmelweis: Right then, it looks like my mission ends here.

Semmelweis: Where are you headed next?

Corvus: To the city. Istanbul.

Semmelweis: Really? Heading back so soon?

Corvus pauses, amusement softening her battle-scarred face.

Corvus: But our next stop is Vienna.

Corvus: We have some passengers who need to get off there.

Semmelweis: Any plans to head east again from Budapest?

Corvus: As long as these wars rage on, there will be people who need our help.

Semmelweis: I wish you all the best, Conductress, with your "secret operation" and with the dream you're chasing.

Corvus: Thank you. I intend to see it happen.

Corvus: And we're making progress. Especially now that I can count on not just one but two vampires to assist me.

She points toward the two "vampires" at her side.

Semmelweis: Haha, indeed. I can only conclude that things will improve from here.

Semmelweis: Perhaps we'll meet again, if we're lucky.

She smiles, waves to the crowd, and turns away.

Rubuska: Phew. I honestly thought she meant it when she said she'd lock us up.

Rubuska: Vampires aren't meant to be locked up in a cell.

Aima: I'm curious, Rubi. If you were given another chance to become a vampire, would you take it?

Ruby eyes dance around and find their rest when they meet Aima's face.

Rubuska: Given a chance? Mm. I don't need "a chance." I am a vampire!

Rubuska: Haven't you heard of me? The nightmare haunting the "Danube Dawn," the terrifying monster—Rubuska the vampire!

Rubuska: She prowls the train, looking for anyone who might cause trouble. And if they do, she'll see them punished.

Rubuska: Investigators? Arcanists? The conductress herself? Hah! She can take them all single-handedly!

Rubuska: And her shadow friends will gobble up anyone who dares stand in her way!

Rubuska: Ah-ha!

Rubuska: Aaaah—

Corvus: "Single-handedly," you say?

Corvus: Let's see how our "monster" manages her chores first. The fifth carriage windows need wiping.

Rubuska: Ch-Chores? How could you do this to me!

Corvus: Funny; I recall someone saying they'd do anything to stay on the train.

Rubuska: Well, yeah, but, we can't have a noble vampire scrubbing windows. We just can't.

A beam of sunlight pierces the morning fog, warming everyone at the station.

Bathed in gold, the conductress's scarred features soften.

Corvus: Jokes aside, I must be clear—working on the "Danube Dawn" is no easy task.

Corvus: You will learn the service manual by heart. And I will be testing you, so you'd better start reading.

The station bustles; soon-to-be passengers rush past, oblivious to the small exchange.

After a night steeped in death and violence, the conductress and her crew brace themselves for a renewed journey.

Still, they dream of these days painted gold by the morning sun.

Guest Room, Foundation

Semmelweis: On November 30th, 1912, I boarded the "Danube Dawn" and encountered a young arcanist named Rubuska and the conductress of the train, Corvus, among others.

Semmelweis: At the Nika checkpoint, we stopped Pyrrhos, a vampire and army officer affiliated with Manus Vindictae, and foiled his scheme to infect the greater population, after which the train successfully entered the territory of Austria-Hungary.

Semmelweis: "Vampire" ...

She stops writing, staring at the report before her. Half-truths have become a specialty of hers.

Semmelweis: It hardly counts as "forging reports" if I simply leave out a few details.

Semmelweis: All that I've written is true. It just "didn't occur to me" to include some minor details.

Foundation Staff Member: Ms. Semmelweis.

Semmelweis: No need to worry. I'll turn in the report by the end of the day.

Foundation Staff Member: Oh, I'm not here for the report.

Semmelweis: Hm?

Foundation Staff Member: Our office in Vienna received a gift. They were asked to pass it along to you.

The young clerk leaves a small gift box by the door and slips away.

Semmelweis: A gift? Could it be ...?

She slices the letter open with her fingernail.

The scrawl is uneven, the corner stained with two thick drops of blood like a wax seal.

Semmelweis: "Dear Ms. Semmelweis of the St. Pavlov Foundation."

Then her eyes fall on the illustrious, overlong, and entirely playful signature.

"The youngest descendant of Arnold V, Voivode of Wallachia; true heir of Savonovic, first Duke of Arges; rightful lady of Castle Arges, daughter of Arnold VI ..."

"... and the bravest vampire of the century, Rubuska, sends her regards!"

Echoes of the "Wind"

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To the UTTU Editorial Team

> Dear colleagues,
>
> Regarding Corvus, the conductress of the "Danube Dawn." As you all know, she was once one of us and my most trusted partner. Thus, for personal reasons as well as curiosity, I have attempted to glimpse traces of the partner I once knew. I must admit, she's changed. There is

barely a trace of the person I remember. The glimmer in her eyes remains, yes, but where that gaze now falls ... no longer has anything to do with me.

Still, in a way, our destinations aren't all too different. For that reason, I still cherish this brief journey we now share.

As for Ms. Pandora Wilson, it's been some time since she vanished. Since then, I've found it difficult to sense her through the wind. It's as if some unseen force quietly erased every trace of her. Yet lately, I've faintly detected something ... an echo which mimics the wind. I have tried many times to reestablish contact, but I've received no response. Even so, I still believe she is out there somewhere.

Despite this, UTTU continues to publish articles in her name and tone. I understand why. Losing her would mean losing the very spirit of UTTU—something none of us could bear. That is why I took it upon myself to handle external correspondence under her name. Yet, the unease lingers: we are all trying to imitate her—her style, her rhythm, the way she thought, the words she might have written ... but none of us truly understand the meaning behind them. For me, this imitation is like calling out a name in the dark, over and over again, knowing it will never answer back.

As for the strange happenings aboard the "Danube Dawn" and the many details pertaining to vampires ... I will explain everything in full once I have alighted.

Verity, UTTU Editor
Written aboard the "Danube Dawn"